You’re the One Thing I Swear I Can’t Outgrow

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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僕のヒーローアカデミア | Boku no Hero Academia | My Hero Academia (Anime & Manga)

Relationships:
Bakugou Katsuki/Midoriya Izuku, Toga Himiko/Uraraka Ochako, Midoriya Izuku & Uraraka Ochako

Characters:
Bakugou Katsuki, Midoriya Izuku, Uraraka Ochako, Past One For All Users (My Hero Academia), Izumi Kouta, Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead, Yagi Toshinori | All Might

Additional Tags:
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by Arkivy

Summary

“Well, all you need to know is that I may not have One for All anymore, but my friends actually made this suit for me! Amazing, right? I’m so blessed!” Older Izuku said.

“Does that include Kacchan, too?” Izuku asked.

“The suit? Yeah—yeah, he pitched in too.”

“Do we—get to be heroes, together?” Izuku braced himself for the eventual dismissal, but still the easy smile his older self wore irked him so much.

“We had a patrol together every now and then,” he answered cordially. His older self was talking about Kacchan like he was just a former classmate he met once every few months, Izuku realized with distaste.

✦✧

Or, Post-PLW Izuku crashed Izuku & Ochako's apartment, 9 years in the future.

Notes

Ending so ass I came out of retirement after 10 years of not writing...Enjoy!

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Midoriya Izuku sneaked a peek at his pocket for the millionth time in the past few hours. A small velvet box sat safely inside, as it had been ten seconds before, and he let himself exhale in relief.

Today, finally, he's going to propose to his girlfriend after dating for a year and a half.

Izuku tugged at the hem of his suit and adjusted his tie with jittery fingers—his last attempt to make himself look presentable—and pushed the door to their shared apartment open with a bright smile.

They had agreed that an intimate proposal was the best for them, and knowing Izuku, he would start bawling his eyes out the moment it started anyway, so it would be best if they did it in the privacy of their home.

Ochako must've heard the sound of the door opening, because she looked up from where she was reading on their couch and beamed at Izuku.

"Izu-kun! You're home!" Ochako greeted him with a sunny smile. She was wearing her favorite pink sweater and had her hair pulled up in a twin bun. She had started wearing the hairstyle more often now—usually only at home because she thought it was a little bit childish. But that meant it's a special hairstyle only Izuku got to see, so he had nothing to complain about, really.

Izuku had just opened his mouth to reply when something—*someone* — materialized out of thin air and crashed against their coffee table. The pair immediately jumped into alert position, the previous tranquil atmosphere forgotten in a flash.

"Ouch!? *Ouch, ouch, ouch…* " Izuku and Ochako whipped their gazes to each other in bewilderment at the familiarity of the voice. Izuku marched closer to where Ochako was to take a better look. Once both of them finally identified their mystery intruder, their identical round eyes widened in surprise.

There, laid half unconscious on Izuku & Ochako's destroyed coffee table, was a visibly younger Izuku in his tattered hero suit with multiple bruises and wounds, not unlike the ones he got from Jaku—

Wait.

"What in the world…" Izuku murmured in disbelief. Phantom aches bursted in his limbs as he took in each and every wound adorning the younger boy's body as he struggled to move.

His wounded doppelganger brought his gaze to the source of the voice and soon was sporting an identical bewildered look, albeit more… bloody.

And Izuku immediately knew this was him—the real Midoriya Izuku from that day. That day when Kacc— *no, he didn't want to think about that.*

"Huh, where…am I?" He barely managed to cough out the question before he lost consciousness, leaving Izuku and Ochako with thousands of unanswered questions.

"Oh my god… What is—Is it a quirk accident?" Ochako trembled at his side, and he reached out his hand around her shoulder in a soothing hug.

"Let's treat his wounds and clean the area first. We can ask him once he wakes up," Izuku gestured to their medicine cabinet, and Ochako nodded, sparing a last glance at the unconscious figure of the mysterious impostor before rushing over to fetch the first aid kit. The upside of being an active hero was that they always overstocked on bandages and medicines. But looking at the blood slowly seeping from the boy's mangled body to their carpet, Ochako wondered if it was going to be enough.

✦✧

…inth! Ninth!

Izuku snapped back into consciousness with a jolt and a gasp. His eyes squinted at the bright sunlight when he forced them open, taking in the white ceiling. *Hospital?* Was his first guess before he lolled his head to the side and saw the broken coffee table already swept to the side and the bloody cream-colored carpet.

Wait— He briefly remembered crashing into something hard and— and saw…

That didn't make any sense! His mind supplied as he sat up abruptly, his entire body immediately screamed in pain. He reached out to the nearest surface he could find and his hand landed on something soft. Huh, it turned out he was laid on a sofa in the middle of an… apartment? Izuku gazed downward and found himself wearing a familiar T-shirt with *T-Shirt* written on it and sweatpants.

Had this shirt already looked this worn out the last time Izuku wore it? And all the bandages… Did he get injured during a fight—

Without warning, the memories are rushing back. Meeting all the Vestiges for the first time, and before that, Shigaraki's cracked face was staring at him. And he remembered getting so angry he almost blacked out because—

Because Kacchan was stabbed by Shigaraki. While protecting *him,* of all people.

Oh my god… Izuku put his head in his hands in horror. *Where is Kacchan right now? Is he alright? I need to see him—fuck…* He tried to push himself to stand, but the dizziness from the blood loss on top of all the wounds was the one that did him in. He swayed dangerously to the open side of the sofa, and was already feeling the pull of gravity before a hand caught and steadied him.

A familiar hand, with a very, very familiar scar.

Izuku looked up and his gaze caught an almost identical pair of emerald orbs staring back at him.

"Whoa— take it easy, okay? Your body definitely can't take any more stress," *His voice is almost identical too, but…deeper?* Izuku concluded. The person in front of him looked identical to him, except he was a good 5-10 years older, he thought. Hard to pinpoint the exact range with the baby face that he now was sure ran in the family. The only clue that the Midoriya Izuku in front of him was a lot

older than he looked was his eyes, which looked more mature (somber?) and the jagged scar running down his cheek.

"How?" Izuku rasped out and choked, only realizing now that his throat was parched. Older Izuku gracefully procured a glass of water and helped him chug it until nothing was left.

"Hmmm…I have no idea either," the older Izuku hummed. "My best guess is that it's a quirk accident. Do you remember where you were before getting transported here?"

"I was—we were at Jaku, right after the fight. Shigaraki got away, and then I was having a conversation with the Vestiges before I felt a pull on my stomach and it pulled me here," Izuku supplied helpfully, though his mind had been going *Kacchan Kacchan Kacchan* the whole time, and his stomach felt like it was filled with lead.

Older Izuku's face was indescribable. Izuku could tell that he probably already guessed where he was coming from, given he had already experienced everything himself. But the hollowness of his face made Izuku shudder. Was he thinking about the event that landed Izuku here, or the *after?* The life Izuku had not yet lived?

"The conversation with the Vestiges…that should happen in the hospital, no?"

“Huh?” Izuku snapped out of his thoughts and when he blinked, the weird expression on Older Izuku’s face was gone. He didn’t remember having been transported to a hospital, though, and told the older version of him as such.

“Maybe something happened to you when your psyche was in the Vestige world…” he contemplated. “Strange—I never remembered something like this happening to m—”

“Oh! Little Izu-kun, you’re awake!” A cheerful voice interrupted older Izuku’s analysis.

“U-uraraka-san?” He called tentatively. There’s something different about how the girl presented herself that’s far from the Uraraka he’s familiar with, but his pain-addled mind wasn’t able to deduce anything. Maybe it’s just age? Not saying that she didn’t age gracefully, she’s definitely very beautiful, but somehow it felt like she was trying too hard to emulate something.

“You can call me Ochako,” she smiled warmly. “How are you feeling? At first we wanted to bring you to a hospital, given your injury. But we’re not too sure of what brought you here in the first place, and we’re afraid it would attract too much attention if 2 Izukus were to be seen by people on the way. So, we called in a favor with Recovery Girl to treat the worst of your injury—though she wasn’t able to completely heal you since you’re low on stamina—you just missed her, by the way.”

“Glad she hasn't left for Okinawa yet; I think she almost had a heart attack seeing me dashing to her apartment at full speed,” Older Izuku piped up.

“See, what did I tell you? Getting an apartment near Chiyo-san is nice, right?” Uraraka-san teased.

“‘Chako? Don’t treat Chiyo-san as your personal nurse; she’s retired!”

“Like you’re one to talk, Mr. I-got-injured-during-combat-training-class-almost-everyday,”

Izuku observed his older self and Uraraka-san bantering with each other almost in disbelief. Sure he was close to his brunette classmate at school, but this seemed…more than just a teasing between friends. He glanced to the side, taking in his surroundings and noticed an apartment that’s clearly lived in by 2 people, by how many things are set up in pairs. *No way… are they?*

He mentally shook his head and chose to start assessing the condition of his body to distract himself from thinking such thoughts. Both his arms and legs are wrapped very tight, but it doesn’t feel as mangled as when it was flapping around when he was fighting in the air. On top of the pain, he felt an unfamiliar churn in his gut that felt like it was pulling his core in every direction.

Somehow it felt like his body was alerting him that he did not belong in this timeline and was trying to eject himself from it. But alas, he had no idea how he ended up here and how to get back.

Older Izuku and Uraraka-san must've noticed Izuku being quiet and contemplative, because Uraraka-san smiled at him and said softly, "Izu-kun, if you need anything please don't hesitate to tell us okay? We'll figure it together."

"Oh! Um, thank you, Uraraka-san," Izuku Stuttered meekly, unused to Uraraka-san calling him by his first name. It must've been true then… *They're…together? In the future?*

A flash of blond hair came across his mind. Izuku was a proven optimist, sure. Even quirkless, he still tried gunning for UA no matter what everyone else thought. Not that he was confident he could be *closer* to Kacchan in some distant future, no—but seeing the confirmation that no, it's not happening, sucks. A few weeks ago he thought he was blessed to just be able to talk normally with Kacchan. But he couldn't help being selfish when presented with the possibilities of *more.*

He let out a choked sob, suddenly very aware of the wetness of his cheeks and two very concerned gazes on him. Before they could ask him what's wrong, he tried his best to steady his voice and asked: "Um, I really would like to see Kacchan," *because the last time I saw him, he was skewered and bleeding to death on my behalf and not*

for any other reason, obviously. He rubbed at his eyes awkwardly hoping it would stop producing fat globs of tears but well, his mom often joked it's her real quirk and Izuku inherited it, so it's definitely not stopping anytime soon.

He was not expecting the silence that followed, however. Izuku looked up to meet their gaze and was met with a pair of stunned, pale expressions. Older Izuku was staring at him with the practiced blankness again, and he saw Uraraka-san glance worriedly at her *boyfriend?* before his mind went to the worst possible conclusion.

"Did…something happen to Kacchan?" His stomach was filled with dread by the split-second hesitation before Older Izuku schooled his expression to be more relaxed.

"Of course not," he coddled, "Kat-Kacchan is okay; he's just very busy doing hero work, so I'm not sure I can just call him here."

Danger sense flared suddenly in his head, and all Izuku could think about was *wrong.*

He's lying. But about wha- A phantom weight on his side, knocking him out of the way. Shigaraki was moving faster than he could react and Kacchan…Kacchan was—

His breath hitched. Something dark curled in his chest, the tightness preventing his lungs from functioning properly. He gasped for air but nothing passed through. The sting from Danger Sense—or was it his own anxiety? Was throbbing on the side of his head, and the ever-present weight in his stomach didn't help. With all the worst possibilities piled into his brain, Izuku spiraled.

Black tendrils exploded from his arms, and Izuku let out choked sobs as Blackwhip was ready to wreak havoc on everything near him.

But then every single one of the tendrils snagged on something.

At the silence that followed, Izuku braced himself to crane his head up from where he unconsciously curled into a fetal position. His hands are still clenched on either side of his head. *Did he use One for All to stop Blackwhip from going haywire?*

To say Izuku was surprised at how his guess was way off was an understatement. What stopped him wasn't Blackwhip, but some kind of an imitation of it. He could feel the static vibrating through *his* Blackwhip, but it felt less organic and more like…support gadgets. His suspicion was confirmed by the half-open suitcase near his older counterpart's leg, and some bits of metal were floating from it to form a gauntlet around his outstretched palms.

I thought he felt off, but I see now, he never felt more thankful to hear the vestiges whispering in his head again. He thought, was this

the second's voice?

"You…don't have One for All?"

The older Izuku looked *stricken* at the question, before withdrawing his suit, and Izuku too tried hard to will Blackwhip away, which was hard considering he was still struggling to breathe and anxious to the point of almost vomiting all over the couch. So Blackwhip chose to wrap carefully around him instead, like a protective cocoon.

The sound of gears whirring filled the space as the mechanical suit flew back inside the case panel by panel, and both Izuku's gaze were locked against each other. He could barely register Uraraka-san offering to call Katsuki— *Is he really alright? Please, I have to know* —and left the room in a hurry.

Silence stretched thin between them for a moment before older Izuku sighed and took a seat beside Izuku on the couch and put his head in his hands. "I don't want you to find out…" he confessed.

"...Why?"

"Well, knowing your future may not be a good thing, right? And we still don't know anything about the quirk that brought you here— what if you ended up messing with the timeline or just making things worse by trying to change it?" Older Izuku leaned his back

against the sofa and shrugged noncommittally. The behavior switch gave Izuku a whiplash.

"You're lying," he accused. This entire situation was weird enough, but seeing his older self acting like everything was fine after such a revelation baffled him.

But, then again, that was Izuku through and through wasn't it? Saying he's fine even though he certainly wasn't to not make people worry.

"I just don't know how to explain, I guess," Older Izuku smiled sheepishly. "I really enjoy my life now, but I also didn't want you to get the wrong idea,"

"About what?"

"Well, all you need to know is that I may not have One for All anymore, but my friends actually made this suit for me! Amazing, right? I'm so blessed," he dodged the question.

Blessed, huh, Izuku's mind circled back to Kacchan again. He wondered if Uraraka-san was really calling Kacchan. *Will he come? Are they even friends in the future?* "Does that include Kacchan, too?" Izuku asked.

"The suit? Yeah—yeah, he pitched in too," Older Izuku affirmed.

"Do we—get to be heroes, together?" Izuku braced himself for the eventual dismissal, but still the easy smile his older self wore irked him so much.

"We had a patrol together every now and then," he answered cordially. His older self was talking about Kacchan like he was just a former classmate he met once every few months, Izuku realized. Blackwhip curled a little possessively around his arms, mirroring Izuku's distaste of the idea.

"I thought—with everything that happened… We're on the way to becoming closer to each other," Izuku confessed, fingers idly playing with Blackwhip in embarrassment of his admission.

Older Izuku hummed; a ghost of regret graced his eyes for a split-second. "Maybe we just…grew up. Friends drifted apart all the time, and we still get to see each other occasionally sometimes. It's not as bad as you think."

Yeah, well, you're convincing no one. Bruce snorted.

Thread carefully, ninth. He's not being truthful. Shinomori warned.

Izuku was thankful for the steady presence the Vestiges provided him. Having multiple people talking over each other in his head was something he never thought he'd experience, but he was glad they were here with him during this bizarre experience.

Because what the fuck was that? Izuku would never—he'd never thought drifting apart from Kacchan was even possible.

Aww, the feeling is mutual, ninth! Banjo cackled and Izuku had to really, really control his expression— fighting the urge to blush— so the older him wouldn't notice.

Suddenly, Izuku felt something hard nudging the back of his wrist, obscured by the cocoon of Blackwhip.

"I- I think I need a moment. Can I use the bathroom, please? I need to, um- pee,"

Older Izuku sighed, clearly thinking Izuku was just having trouble accepting his reasoning regarding Katsuki.

"Sure, it's this way."

He gestured to the door across the living room, and Izuku stood up —or tried to before wincing slightly and sitting back down. *Shit,* he had forgotten about his injuries in his haste.

"Oh, sorry— sorry, let me help," Older Izuku hooked an arm around Izuku and helped it stand up, guiding him to the bathroom. "You can use Blackwhip as a splinter and to puppeteer your body, you know," It sounded like he's speaking from experience. *Just what have I gone through in the future to have learned how to do that?*

"Thank you," Izuku nodded slightly as he leaned on the bathroom vanity.

"No worries! Take your time and don't hesitate to call if you need help, okay? I'll just be outside."

With that, the bathroom door was closed.

Izuku immediately locked the bathroom door with the softest click he could manage so as to not raise suspicion. Sitting over the toilet with a wince, he quickly pulled out a smartphone hidden in his pocket. *His future self's phone. Thank God for Blackwhip.*

Yeahhh my quirk is the best!

Quick thinking, kid. Good job. Second's deep voice managed to pull out a blush from him. He had no business praising him while looking like *Kacchan!* It's so unfair.

He shook that thought to focus on the task at hand. He opened the phone and was expecting to have his heart broken by a lock screen of the couple, but instead it was a…teaching…schedule?

Huh? Is he a teacher in the future? That was unexpected. He thought by the presence of the suit he would still become an active hero even without One for All? Suddenly his reluctance to tell Izuku more about the future kind of made sense. The schedule detailed all his teaching classes at UA for the week, and on the weekend there's a schedule marked differently than the rest: *Patrolling with Ochako-chan!* It read.

That's the only time anything hero patrol-related was mentioned in the schedule. So hero work had become a side job for him, or what? Well, teaching *can* be considered a heroic job, he supposed, but to have the ratio be this disproportionate is unbelievable to him—he'd seen *Aizawa-sensei* juggling his teaching job and patrol time better than this!

He tried to open the phone lock and realized it had a facial recognition lock. He almost panicked thinking everything was all for naught before Shimura-san whispered in his ear. *Now, now. Maybe you should try to open the phone as usual first before panicking?*

"Huh? What do you mean?" Izuku positioned the phone so his whole face was visible, and the phone unlocked just like that.

Your baby face just saved the day!! Banjo cheered, and the rest of the Vestiges chuckled alongside him. Izuku could even feel Yoichi-san smiling in mirth as he blushed. *He's never going to live this down, is he?*

Let's focus before he realized his phone was missing, the Second's stern voice snapped Izuku back into focus. *What do you want to search first?*

Well, I doubt I can just gugle how to teleport home, Izuku reasoned as he typed *Bakugou Katsu- wait no, Dynamight.* The way his older self had been mentioning Kacchan had been really weird, and Izuku couldn't shake the uneasiness and worry he felt for Kacchan ever since he got here. So sue him, but finding out that Kacchan was really okay was his priority.

The first thing that popped out in the search engine was a video with over one hundred million views titled: *TOP 10 MOMENTS OF THE WAR!* Izuku clicked on it immediately before he could hesitate.

Wait, which war are they talking about? En piped up.

The video started with Shigaraki seemingly controlling a humongous blob of mutated fingers that filled more than half the screen. They could see a small silhouette of Mirko hopping around and Lemillion phasing through the fingers to scale against the grotesque monstrosity.

Oh shit, what the fuck is that!? Banjo screamed near Izuku's ears and he almost jumped out of the toilet seat straight to the floor. His anxiety was at an all-time high, and this was like a confirmation of something happening in the future that's going to change everything.

The war. THE War.

This was it, then. His final duty as One for All wielder… He almost felt his earlier bravado when talking about saving Shigaraki mocking him when no one even managed to touch the enhanced Shigaraki, even if he was obviously not using Decay. He gasped in awe when he saw Kacchan blazing brightly in the sky with all of his explosion, before he realized something.

He wasn't there.

A sickening crunch could be felt as Shigaraki on the screen managed to grab Kacchan and crush his right arm, and Izuku's life crumbled into ruins.

Kid, breathe! He could hear the Vestiges trying to calm him down, but he couldn't for the life of him tear his gaze away from the screen. For a moment, he thought Kacchan was going to be okay—*How could he doubt him? His Symbol of Victory?* He thought, as Kacchan blazed through the sky in utter brilliance with his explosions. Izuku was captivated as Kacchan managed to dodge Shigaraki and even landed a few blows unlike the others before.

Until he didn't.

Shigaraki somehow managed to land a *devastating blow on Kacchan's chest,* and all the other heroes present weren't fast enough to save him.

Izuku took in the way Kacchan's bloodied body spun in the air like a rag doll before it landed on the floor, unmoving. He could see Best Jeanist desperately calling for Kacchan when he just lay there motionless. As if on cue, the camera chose to zoom in at that exact moment, and all of Izuku's hope withered away the moment he saw Kacchan's brilliant crimson eyes slowly dimmed away.

Several things happened at the same time. He could hear the Vestiges trying to pull him out of a panic attack when Blackwhip exploded everywhere in response to his grief. He couldn't breathe—he couldn't! *Not when he failed Kacchan; why wasn't he there?* He sobbed.

He barely registered the bathroom door being blasted open as he lost all the power left in his legs and just wept into the cold bathroom floor.

Shit, he's really the one who stole my phone!

Bakugou-kun! Don't slam our bathroom door so harshly!

Izuku felt like he was drowning. He heaved and clawed his hands at his chest, struggling to breathe. His throat was scratched dry from all the forced breath his body's survival instinct forced him to take. His head was spinning in delirium, and the ever-present pull on his stomach might just be the final trigger. His frail, barely recovering post-battle body was NOT made to withstand multiple panic attacks in the span of an hour.

He was halfway floating into unconsciousness before a gentle hand softly cradled his face and wiped away the vomit left on the side of his mouth. *I don't remember…vomiting,* he thought as his senses gradually came back as the person gently moved his head to the side so as not to choke on his own vomit. His back was laid on the bathroom floor still, with his face on someone's lap. A familiar scent flooded his senses as he finally took a deep breath that didn't hurt. He felt his body going slack a little as he opened his eyes.

“I-Izuku…”

Izuku’s jaw slacked open at the sight above him. Kacchan was here, staring down at him—cradling him on his lap and looking very much *alive.*

✦✧

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading until the end! The chapters have all been drafted already, but I might need time to finish polishing everything because I'm more rusty than I thought haha. Kindly leave comments and kudos below if you like it! See you soon~

Title is from Ocean & Engines by Niki!

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> “K-Kacchan, about the scar on your arm…”
>
> “It's nothing I can handle, no need to get worked up about it.” His tone was curt and dismissive, but Izuku didn’t miss how his grip on the steering wheel tightened.
>
> “I’m sorry…Is it because I wasn’t there?” Izuku made a guess. Kacchan had come with him willingly in their fight against Shigaraki just before Izuku was sent here, but in the video he just watched, he was nowhere to be found. When he told Kacchan as such, Kacchan used his good hand to lightly knock him in the head but chose to say nothing.
>
> Izuku pouted and tried very hard to conceal the tears that had already started running through his cheeks. Kacchan not outright denying it meant it was true. Kacchan quickly caught his attempt to hide a sniffle and scoffed.
>
> “Such a crybaby. I’m still alive and well, am I not? Not everything is your responsibility, All Might’s successor-sama.”

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Watching Katsuki and his younger self interact felt like having an out-of-body experience, Izuku thought when he was standing in front of his guest bathroom’s door. Katsuki’s the gentlest he had ever seen him in their whole lives growing up together, and Izuku swallowed down the ugly feeling rising in his chest. Was he jealous of his younger self for being the center of Katsuki’s world? Or because at some point in navigating adulthood, Izuku never cared to

stop running away from the drowning chaos in his mind to witness Katsuki's sharp edges slowly rounded off into something more… tender.

When did Kacchan simply become Katsuki to him? He wondered.

The weight of the forgotten ring box in his pants pocket seemed to be mocking him. To think that this morning he thought that he was happy. He's proposing to his girlfriend; he's a teacher of very bright future heroes, and he's still an active hero on the weekends with Ochako. But now, he wasn't too sure anymore.

Make sure you do your damn best. Tenko's last words echoed in his mind.

Had he not done his damn best ever since he failed? Was he just following through the motions, never allowing himself to think, to *grieve?* He lost One for All and eventually the embers; of course he could still be a teacher. His friends are off saving the world away from him, and he's stuck doing college assignments and teaching internships; of course they couldn't meet each other that much. That's why he only reconnected with Ochako after he got the suit—and she's been such an angel to him, a kindred spirit with similar souls and shared pain, so *of course* they'll marry and maybe have a little family together someday. It's just the natural progression after all, and all that he convinced himself he deserved.

He thought that he no longer deserved to live out his grand dreams of heroism—especially with *Kacchan, his symbol of victory,* because he had failed Tenko.

Maybe that Izuku truly died with Tenko that day.

But with all that said and done, he was content with what he had now. He finally tore his gaze from Katsuki and his younger self when he felt Ochako's palm sliding into his, and he gave her a half-smile that never reached his eyes and squeezed her hand back.

He's fine.

✦✧

Izuku couldn't believe his eyes. Kacchan was alive. *Kacchan was alive* . He's alive and *grown* ; traces of adolescence already replaced with sharp jaws and broad shoulders—and *oh* , the jagged scar on Kacchan's right cheek reminded Izuku that the video he just watched was actually real. "Kacchan… You're alive…" Izuku sobbed again, still immensely shaken by the earlier video.

The frown on Kacchan's face was heartbreaking, like he was worried about Izuku (He sure hoped he wasn't delusional), and he wanted to do nothing but comfort and erase the tears on his face. Now Izuku was one hundred percent sure that he got transported into an alternate reality somehow, with himself acting so detached from anything and Kacchan not resorting to anger as his default emotion and just being openly vulnerable with *him* of all people.

Kacchan gently pried apart his fingers from crushing his older self's phone— *oh no, he had forgotten about that.* He cringed in guilt as he took in the state of the phone; it was definitely crushed some time during his breakdown, with some pieces and bits stuck to his reddened palm. Kacchan then chucked the remains carelessly to Izuku's older self, who was caught off guard and immediately tore his hand from Uraraka-san's to catch it.

The handholding part was still uncanny to witness, actually.

"Always a reckless nerd, huh?" Kacchan's gruff voice lacked his usual bite, and Izuku thought he was referring to his older self at first. Then he glanced away from his older self back to Kacchan and immediately caught his gaze. Was he only looking at him the whole time? Izuku was immediately hyperaware of Kacchan's presence again. He had to fight back a blush as Kacchan held his hands to examine the cuts. "Can you stand?"

"Ah—y-yes!" Izuku rushed to stand up but immediately lost any remaining strength in his legs. He cursed himself for forgetting that

his body had been through hell and back— *again* . All because Kacchan kept looking at him funny.

Before he could kiss the floor, however, a pair of steady hands managed to catch him and pick him up like a sack of potatoes.

"Whoa— *K-Kacchan??* " Izuku was flailing in Kacchan's shoulder wildly until he could feel one of his injuries getting pulled from the motion and immediately stopped, wincing in pain.

"That's what you get for being a brat," Kacchan snorted before depositing him on one of the dining chairs. He turned to Uraraka-san and demanded, "First aid kit."

Uraraka-san huffed. "Such audacity from someone who's too good to keep in touch with us these last few months…" But she did grab the half-empty first aid kit and pass it to Kacchan.

Izuku was waiting for Kacchan's biting comeback but he remained strangely silent, opting to focus on treating Izuku's additional self-inflicted injury.

"Now while I patch up this idiot's hands, does anybody care enough to fill me in?"

And so Older Izuku took a seat opposite Kacchan & Izuku at the table and started recounting everything that happened in the last hour. Kacchan frowned as the story went on but remained silent until Older Izuku finished his story.

"So you really got your phone stolen by your younger self, eh, *Deku-sensei?* So much for setting a good example for the future generation of heroes," Kacchan sneered with narrowed eyes. Izuku whipped his head up to look at Kacchan. The tone of Kacchan's taunt was reminiscent of what Izuku used to hear his entire life, but now it just lacked *something* . Izuku took in Kacchan's clenched fists after he finished tending to Izuku's wound and the way his shoulders pulled taut, like he was waiting for a fight.

It lacked any real malice because he's just baiting him, Izuku realized.

Older Izuku didn't take the bait, however. He just smiled and sheepishly rubbed the back side of his head. "Well, I guess I just got old!"

Izuku was almost offended at that, honestly.

Since when were you such a pushover? He jolted in shock at the sound of— *was it the third?* —echoing in one side of his head.

Sorry, ninth, we're not sure when to come in so as to not overwhelm you, Shimura-san explained. Izuku nodded slightly in acknowledgment, eyes still on Kacchan.

He was so engrossed in what Kacchan was about to retort back that he was caught completely off guard by the loud stomach rumbling noise that suddenly broke the tense atmosphere in the room. The noise that came from *his* stomach.

Oh noooooooo…No, No, No. Please just kill me right now. Izuku was mortified. Then he remembered that technically, he hadn't eaten for the entire day the Raid was happening, so of course he was hungry. But the timing of it made him want to just walk straight to Shigaraki and let him decay Izuku into nothingness.

Especially when Kacchan turned to look at him slack-jawed.

"Oh! You must be so hungry after fighting and getting healed! Sorry for our oversight; let me prepare something for you to ea-" Uraraka-san was the first to break the silence and strode to the fridge before she was cut off.

"Nah, don't bother; I'll take him out to eat," Kacchan said and lifted Izuku up in a bridal carry.

“Waah-chan!?” Izuku flailed in Kacchan’s arms (*Kacchan’s arms!!)* before Kacchan tsked at him.

“Just stay put and don’t aggravate your wound further, *Izuku.* ”

Izuku immediately stayed very still. Kacchan just called him Izuku. *Kacchan just called him Izuku.* He could feel the blush creeping up his neck and ears, and he prayed that it’s not that noticeable. Kacchan took one good look at him, huffed, and turned to face older Izuku.

“Bye, Deku.”

If Kacchan’s voice rang with more finality than any goodbye between two friends should, no one dared to voice it out loud.

✦✧

“Whoa…” Izuku was in heaven. Actually, he’s resting on the backseat of Kacchan’s fancy car, which felt *amazing* against his aching body.

Kacchan rummaged through one of the compartments in his car and pulled out a black hoodie. “Here,” he threw the hoodie in Izuku's direction, whose reaction was just a lame “Uh?” because he’s not moving a single muscle any time soon; it’s *that* comfortable.

“You kept shivering since the bathroom,” Kacchan explained, and Izuku blushed.

“Ah, thank you, Kacchan,” Izuku pulled himself upright and slid the hoodie over his head. It was much bigger than he thought. *Kacchan really is a grown-up now;* Izuku felt a pang in his chest at the realization. He saw Kacchan moving to sit in the driver’s seat and starting his car and made a split-second decision to follow him to the passenger seat.

Kacchan raised an eyebrow at him. “You should just rest at the back, nerd.”

Izuku sent him a determined look. “I think I would pass out for hours if I spent even one more minute on it, honestly,” he sent Kacchan a sheepish look. “I’d much rather talk to you.”

Wow, smooth, ninth. Someone snickered in the back of his head.

“I-I mean about this weird…situation! I’d like to discuss it with you, if you don’t…mind,” Izuku trailed off, flustered. Of all the pros and

cons of having One for All, Izuku never thought it would include seven? (All Might's wisp of a vestige was there hanging out at the back, and Izuku wondered if the real All Might could sense anything happening to Izuku on his end) people having a commentary on his life.

All Might's mentor, Shimura-san, chuckled. *Sorry, Izuku-kun. We're new at this, too. Just tune us out but remember we'll always be there if you need us, okay?*

Izuku nodded a silent thanks before schooling his expression to look at Kacchan again. He had expected Kacchan to explode at him the way he always did for even trying to open a conversation with him, but Kacchan was strangely silent. Instead, he was looking up and down at Izuku with a weird expression on his face before snapping his gaze to the road and starting to drive.

Izuku raised his eyebrow in confusion before trying to see what Kacchan was looking at to make him look constipated. He patted himself down to check on his bandages before realizing that his hands were essentially covered with Kacchan's hoodie sleeve, with the shoulder hanging off to one side. *Oh, Kacchan is always a very tidy person; maybe he just doesn't like me looking unkempt?* Izuku fixed the oversized hoodie and rolled the sleeves back self-consciously before glancing at Kacchan again.

No reaction. Maybe this was really why, Izuku thought as he warily leaned his back against the car seat, eyes still on Kacchan.

The ride was silent for a few minutes before Izuku braced himself to ask, “K-Kacchan, about the scar on your arm…”

Kacchan let out a sigh and tore his gaze from the road to glance at Izuku briefly. “Nothing I can handle, no need to get worked up about it.” His tone was curt and dismissive, but Izuku didn’t miss how his grip on the steering wheel tightened.

“I’m sorry…Is it because I wasn’t there?” Izuku made a guess. Kacchan had come with him willingly in their fight against Shigaraki just before Izuku was sent here, but in the video he just watched, he was nowhere to be found. When he told Kacchan as such, Kacchan used his good hand to lightly knock him in the head but chose to say nothing.

Izuku pouted and tried very hard to conceal the tears that had already started running through his cheeks. Kacchan not outright denying it meant it was true. Kacchan quickly caught his attempt to hide a sniffle and scoffed.

“Such a crybaby. I’m still alive and well, am I not? Not everything is your responsibility, All Might’s successor-*sama.* ”

“Kacchan, I just saw you getting impaled a few hours ago to push me out of harm’s way and then saw that you survived only to get

blasted point-blank by Creepy Shigaraki Hands in the future—how did you not *decay* , anyway?— And then I thought you died when I wasn't there to help you, *and then* I found out that you're alive. Maybe I'm allowed to be emotional about it," Izuku took a long breath after rambling his frustration in one sentence. He's so tired.

That shut Kacchan up pretty quickly. Izuku took this opportunity to ramble on— even about the things he thought he'd never be brave enough to say directly to his Kacchan. This Kacchan hadn't exploded him yet, anyway, so Izuku felt *safe* to continue on.

"W-when you got stabbed the first time, Kacchan—it was so awful. I think I must have blacked out at some point? I-I couldn't think of anything else but to punch Shigaraki to oblivion for h-hurting you," Izuku warbled frustratingly. "I felt so ashamed for even thinking that —what kind of a hero am I, Kacchan? Especially since after that, I think I…saw a crying child inside him for a moment— and now I want to save him too, despite everything. Does that make me…a hypocrite?" He sobbed painfully into his hands.

"Goddammit, Izuku," Kacchan finally broke his silence with a growl. "Shit, this is all my fault, isn't it? It's always been my fucking fault since the start— I did this to you."

"Kacchan?"

“Look, Izuku—” Kacchan took a deep breath before continuing. “I’m so bad at this, but I have to try, okay? Can’t take any more regrets. You—you’ve always been a hero from the start, Izuku.”

Izuku’s eyes widened at Kacchan’s confession.

Kacchan’s eyes never left the road, driving steadily even when he stumbled upon his next words: “Your heroism is always a part of you, even when you didn’t have One for All. Even my kid self knew that. I was fucking threatened by a quirkless you because you embody my ideal heroism better than I am,” Kacchan took a shaky breath before continuing.

“But in all your selflessness, you always forget to take yourself into account too,” Kacchan’s fingers were tapping the steering wheel to ease his own distress. “You’re only human, Izuku. Don’t choke yourself over your ideal to only end up as an unfeeling machine. I did not realize it until it was too late the first time, so at least for you —” Izuku shivered at the intensity of Kacchan’s gaze, even though he was not facing him directly. It did make him wonder, though: was he speaking to *Izuku* or the Izuku he left in the apartment he shared with Uraraka-san?

“Please never lose sight of yourself. I was wrong— you’re never an extra or anything like that, so don’t treat yourself as one.” Izuku was openly sobbing at this point, and Kacchan blinked away a few stray tears himself.

“It’s okay to let yourself feel, Izuku.”

And just like that, the dam broke. They should’ve put a manual on how to approach a delicate conversation and put a big warning sign on having one in a *moving car* , because Blackwhip went haywire on Kacchan’s car, and not even the best driver could recover that quickly from the shock.

The car swerved to the side dangerously before Kacchan expertly steered it back to the middle lane with his scarred hand, because for some reason, Blackwhip attached itself to Kacchan’s left arm and refused to let go.

“What the fuck, Izuku? Do you want to fucking die?”

“I’m so sorry, Kacchan! Blackwhip suddenly isn't listening to me—” Izuku tried to reel Blackwhip back to no avail; it’s still stubbornly attaching itself to Kacchan’s arm. *It’s like they’re holding hands* , Izuku realized, mortified.

A-hem, I did say that Blackwhip is controlled through your heart, didn’t I? Banjo supplied helpfully. Izuku choked on his own saliva and proceeded to curl himself into a ball in embarrassment.

Kacchan snickered despite having one of his hands held hostage, and when Izuku peeked through his hands, he could see Kacchan’s

signature grin greeting him light-heartedly.

Oh , his heart did a somersault at the sight. *Mature, calm Kacchan is amazing to behold, but happy, grinning Kacchan is the best Kacchan, after all.*

Blackwhip dissipated eventually when Izuku was about to crash out from exhaustion. Kacchan ruffled his hair and quietly told him to rest until they got to the restaurant.

“Thank you… Kacchan…”

Feeling the last of his tension melted away, Izuku drifted to sleep.

✦✧

Chapter End Notes

Writing oblivious Izuku from Izuku's perspective was an experience...(I wanna shake him and listen to his brain rattle inside his head because Kacchan didn't care if you wore the hoodie messily okay, he just thought your sweaterpaws were cute as hell)

By the way, I'm playing Drivers Licence by Olivia Rodrigo on loop every time I was writing this chapter... Y*utube please stop recommending break-up song to me challenge.

I hope you enjoyed the chapter! KIndly let me know what you think of it! Hopefully you don't need to wait too long for the next chapter, but I was inspired to make 137378 BKDK merch so I'll be focusing on that first~

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> "Kacchan, you made the suit? He said it was from everyone!"
>
> "Everyone pitched in when they found out. But at the start it was just me, All Might, Hatsume, and Melissa," Kacchan sighed. "Not that it mattered, though; even with them helping, it was already too late. I thought he would be overjoyed to finally return as an active hero again, but he— when I asked him to join my hero agency— he declined, saying he enjoyed teaching more now." Kacchan furiously chomped on a big mouthful of Katsudon and rice.
>
> "What the fuck?"
>
> Kacchan instantly choked on the rice.

Chapter Notes

> Thank you so much for 100+ Kudos!! Enjoy the long long chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"So, what's your running theory?"

Kacchan and Izuku took their seats at the corner of a small mom-and-pop restaurant. The decor was obviously done by an All Might fan, Izuku noted in delight. There were a lot of vintage collections too, so he can easily deduce that the owners of the establishment were an All Might's fan for a long time.

“Hmm…The last thing I remembered doing before I crashed here was talking to the Vestiges in the Vestiges realm.” Izuku put a finger on his chin, trying hard to recall anything that could be used as a clue. “Before that, l think I was being transported to a hospital?” Izuku added while trying to read the restaurant’s menu. He was still wearing Kacchan’s hoodie with the hood up at the insistence of Kacchan, so he wouldn’t get recognized by random people.

“So you haven’t actually woken up in the hospital yet?” Kacchan asked. “Was that why you arrived here all beaten up in your tattered hero costume? The vestiges talk should've happened when you're in a coma at the hospital.”

“I was in a coma!?” How come his older self never mentioned anything about that?

“Nothing too long, nerd, relax. By the way, the Katsudon here is to die for,” Kacchan suggested.

“Oh! I’m definitely getting that! I wondered If they do a small portion though, my stomach has been acting weird; I don’t want to end up wasting the Katsudon by vomiting it back up,” Izuku patted his stomach sadly.

“Stomachache?”

"Yeah, but it felt… different from a normal stomachache somehow. It's like there's an anchor in my gut constantly pulling me away from here. Is it maybe because I'm not supposed to be here? My older self also mentioned that he didn't remember anything about this."

"That may be so. Maybe you are from a parallel universe or something, instead of the past. We can just share a bowl, by the way. I've already eaten lunch, so I'm not that hungry," Kacchan motioned to the owner that they're ready to order.

"Eh, but *Kacchannnn,* you always put too much chili flakes on the Katsudon!"

"Heh, not my fault your palate is as weak as a newborn's, 'Zuku," Kacchan snickered.

Izuku was about to sass back, but the owner had already reached their table with notepad in hand. He was an old man in his 50s, wearing an All Might-themed apron and holding a matching All Might pen. Izuku wanted to nerd out about it so badly, but he didn't want to be recognized. "Katsuki! It's been a while since I last saw you! And who's this?" He peered curiously at Izuku, who instinctively lowered his head to further hide his face.

"He's, uh, Izuku's cousin from the countryside. I'm just showing him around town," the owner seemed to buy Kacchan's last-minute lie with a hum and a nod.

“Izuku, huh…Been a while since I last saw you two together! Especially you— I haven’t seen you much this past year. Izuku, on the other hand, came every other week with that brown-haired girlfriend of his and with more All Might merch to add to my collection, to boot!” The restaurant’s owner gestured excitedly to one of the shelves, and Izuku’s eyes almost bulged out of his head.

He’d recognize that exact scratch on the base of All Might’s Silver Age limited edition figurine anywhere; he’d cried over it at least fifteen separate times in middle school because he accidentally tripped and damaged the base when unboxing!

Which meant the figurine was his. His older self had been giving his precious limited-edition collection away to this restaurant’s owner for whatever reason Izuku couldn't fathom, because for him it would be over his dead body.

He locked eyes with Kacchan, mouth still agape in bewilderment, but Kacchan was still processing the other thing the owner had said. “Izuku came here?”

“Yeah, that’s what I just told you, boy! He’s been here a few times with his girlfriend—I couldn’t remember her name exactly. Wasn’t a big All Might fan, though she clearly tried to be enthusiastic about it,” the owner actually sulked at the prospect of older Izuku dating a non-All Might fan, which made Izuku giggle inwardly for some reason.

“Anyway, what do you want to order, boys?” The owner finally remembered what he was here for and propped his notepad and pen, ready to write their order.

Kacchan only took a second to collect himself. “Your special Mighty Katsudon, please. With California Smash Fried Gyoza on the side and two glasses of hot tea. Oh—and please put my usual extra chili flakes separately, I’m sharing with this idiot who couldn’t handle his spice,” Kacchan gestured to Izuku, who just pouted.

“Coming right up! Glad to see you after so long, Katsuki. Holler at me if you need anything!” The owner strode back to the open kitchen to start preparing their order, leaving Kacchan and Izuku in silence for a second.

“Is this really a parallel universe? Why would my future self give away my All Might merch collection? Did you know how much I saved for that one?” Izuku broke the silence with a hiss and gestured at the Silver Age figurine with the damaged base sitting innocently on the shelf.

Kacchan raised an eyebrow at him with a teasing smile. “I thought you’d be okay sharing merch with a fellow All Might *enthusiast?* Aoi-san is one of the real ones and you respect him a lot.”

"Well— if that's the case, I'd just gift him a brand-new one then. Why would I—Ugh this is so confusing." Izuku put his head on his hands.

"Stop thinking about this too hard, nerd. You'll fry your brain," Kacchan flicked Izuku's forehead lightly.

"Well, your younger self would lose his mind too if he's the one who woke up in the future and found out he had become a completely different person… At least you still feel like you."

"Are you saying that I haven't changed at all since high school? Ouch, nerd." Kacchan raised an eyebrow at him in mock hurt.

Izuku absent-mindedly played with the provided utensils at the table while pouting at him. "You know what I mean, Kacchan. You're still a hero— and you have a very cool, fancy-looking car! And you look very handsome and mature now, too… I'm sure younger you would have nothing to worry abou—" It took Izuku 5 seconds of staring at Kacchan's blushing, wide-eyed face before he realized that he had called Kacchan *handsome* to his face. He could immediately feel his own face heating up too and he immediately tried to backtrack.

"No— wait, what I mean is—!"

“Your order’s here!” The restaurant owner’s booming voice almost made Izuku jump out of his seat in surprise. His face must be the deepest shade of red now, so he just hid behind the oversized hoodie as the owner laid out their late lunch.

“Wait, Aoi-san, we didn’t order this—” Kacchan’s voice made Izuku peek his eyes from in between his hands.

“It’s your favorite Plus Ultra Spicy Karaage, on the house! Thank you for always keeping our neighborhood safe, Dynamight! We always believe in you, screw the rank or the news; you’ll always be our hero!” Aoi-san patted Kacchan enthusiastically on the back. “Sorry for laying it a little thick, boy, but you didn’t come back here for quite some time, and we really don’t want to miss this chance again,” the man gestured to the open kitchen and his wife and few of the employees gave Kacchan a thumbs up before going back to their job.

Izuku could tell Kacchan was touched but was obviously unused to the praise, so he just nodded and bowed slightly at the older man as he finished setting up the table and left them to enjoy their meal.

“Kacchan’s so cool…” Izuku’s words were muffled by his palms, but Kacchan heard it all the same. He cleared his throat in embarrassment and gestured to the food.

“Just shut up and eat the food before you die from acid reflux, nerd.” Kacchan picked up his chopsticks and reached for the spicy karaage first; because of course he would.

“Mmm! *Itadakimasu* !”

“ *...Itadakimasu,”* Kacchan mumbled under his breath before taking a big bite of the karaage. He immediately groaned in bliss. Only this place was gutsy enough to make a menu with Kacchan’s spice tolerance level, after all. He’d missed this flavor so much.

Izuku took a bite of the Katsudon and whoa— it was definitely one of the best Katsudon he’d ever tasted in his life! The cutlet’s meat-to-crumb ratio was perfect, and the sauce and rice were cooked to perfection, too! Just the way Izuku liked it— Did Kacchan like it too? He must, right? Didn’t he come here regularly before—

Izuku looked up from his rambling to find Kacchan staring at him with soft eyes and an almost smile gracing his lips. Izuku’s heart stuttered at the sight; it really hammered home that he never saw Kacchan without an angry scowl on his face back in his time. He truly looked *handsome* , Izuku affirmed. But something in his gaze was also sad, and that, Izuku didn’t like.

“Kacchan?” Izuku’s gears were turning in his head, trying to find the right words. “Earlier, Aoi-san said that you haven’t been coming here lately, even though older me still does. What really happened

between the two of you in the future?" *Between us,* Izuku had wanted to say, but it didn't feel right.

Kacchan spooned a little bit of Katsudon and rice from his side of the bowl, lathering it with chili flakes before taking his time chewing it slowly.

Izuku waited patiently until he finished, eyes never leaving Kacchan.

Kacchan let out a resigned sigh before finally finding his answer. "So you… already found out about the suit, am I right?"

Izuku nodded.

"After losing One for All, he's been…different," Kacchan stated carefully. "For eight years, it's like I'm watching him drowning without being able to do anything. He just brushed any attempt to help with an empty smile and said stuff like 'I'm fine!' I know even Aizawa is tired of his bullshit," Kacchan paused to poke at his karaage before popping one more in his mouth. Izuku followed suit with the gyoza. It was as delicious as the Katsudon.

"Aizawa-sensei?"

"Heh— he's your coworker now, can you believe it?" *No,* Izuku blanched at the mere thought of it.

"I've never been good with words, I told you. So I thought, if I couldn't get through him with words, I'd just show it with my action. Hence, the suit."

"Kacchan, you *made* the suit? He said it was from everyone!"

"Everyone pitched in when they found out. But at the start it was just me, All Might, Hatsume, and Melissa," Kacchan sighed. "Not that it mattered, though; even with them helping, it was already too late. I thought he would be overjoyed to finally return as an active hero again, but he— when I asked him to join my hero agency— he declined, saying he enjoyed teaching more now." Kacchan furiously chomped on a big mouthful of Katsudon and rice.

"What the *fuck* ?"

Kacchan instantly choked on the rice.

"That's *bullshit!* Kacchan, are you *sure* he's the real me and not some imposter?" Izuku was truly losing it now. Of all the reasons to crash out, this was the one that took the cake and smashed it to the fucking ground.

“Since when did you curse!?” Kacchan yelled after taking a swig of his tea to ease his throat.

“ *Kacchan* , I’ve been dreaming of becoming heroes with you my whole life. I still remember wanting to be a part of your Hero Agency when we were kids,” Izuku explained heatedly. “During the raid, when you followed me as I went out on my own, it made me really happy. I like being heroes together with you,” Izuku got teary-eyed again at the realization that his older self could’ve gotten everything he’d ever wanted and decided to just throw it all away. “I just couldn’t understand why.”

“I think when he lost One for All, he lost that part of himself. Everything I told you in the car, I wish I could tell him the same thing, you know. But it’s too late now. We’ve drifted apart too much.”

“I hated that, us drifting apart,” Izuku pouted. The rest of the meal seemed less flavorful now.

“That makes the two of us,” Kacchan sighed before running a hand through his hair.

“What’s the deal with Uraraka-san, then?” Izuku had finished his meal and started playing with Kacchan’s car key, tapping it with his

fingers repeatedly like a fidget toy.

"Hell if I know. Everyone was fucking surprised when the news dropped."

Izuku raised his eyebrow at him. "Did you drift apart with older me because of that?"

"Nah, it's not that. For the first few months after they got hitched, nothing has changed, actually. He still asked me to guest teach at UA often, and we did occasionally patrol together whenever he was able to. But then he started scheduling his weekend patrol with Cheeks and Cheeks only, so I thought I had overstayed my welcome and just— went zero contact until this afternoon," Katsuki admitted dismissively, but Izuku could tell he was deeply hurt.

Izuku continued clicking on Kacchan's key before taking it in his hands to play with it some more, offended that his older self treated heroism as a mere weekend leisure activity.

Izuku absent-mindedly flipped the attached keychain to Kacchan's car key and gasped audibly. All Might's signature smile greeted him in the form of a hero trading card, which Izuku was so sure was the ultra-rare one he pulled from a potato chip bag together with Kacchan when they were four years old. There was an obvious sign of wear and tear on the card, like it had been run through hell and back before it got shoved into a protective case. *But it was signed.*

“Oh my god… You kept it all this time, Kacchan?” Izuku’s previous ire was replaced by a sudden wave of nostalgia.

“Yeah,” Katsuki rasped, with a slight tint of red dusting his cheeks.

“I kept mine, too,” Izuku confessed. It had been one of his most treasured merch ever. It’s his first-ever All Might merch, and he got it with Kacchan. He kept it safely in a toploader ever since he first got it.

“Hey, Kacchan,” Izuku was still admiring the card when he spoke. “Can I…come visit your hero agency?”

Kacchan’s chopsticks stopped in their tracks to pick the last piece of gyoza. “Are you sure? It probably isn’t what you imagined in your nerdy-ass brain,” he asked pensively.

“Uh-huh! I’m sure it’s amazing. I want a tour, please!”

“Did you not hear what I just said? Lower your expectations, nerd!” Katsuki groaned frustratingly and gestured for his car key. Izuku dutifully handed it back.

Kacchan paid for the meal after much difficulty— Aoi-san refused to let him pay until Kacchan said he'd come here more often if he let him pay for today's meal— and soon they're on the road again, heading to Kacchan's hero agency! Izuku was giddy with excitement.

They arrived shortly at a brand-new three-story building not too far from the restaurant, and Izuku couldn't contain his eagerness anymore. He jumped out of the passenger seat the moment Kacchan finished parking his car and ran to get a good view of the building. It was a sleek building covered with black glass panels and an orange x accent with the logo 'Great Explosion Murder God Dynamight' embellished atop the big entrance. *It's so Kacchan;* Izuku almost sobbed in relief.

Izuku could feel Kacchan slowly walking towards where he was standing and turned to face him. "Your agency is the coolest, Kacchan!"

Kacchan turned a little pink at that but made no comment except for a grunt. He gestured for Izuku to follow him inside with a tilt of his head, and Izuku cheerfully obliged.

Kacchan used his fingerprints to unlock the door, and they stepped inside the empty agency together.

"Huh, there's no one inside?" Izuku tilted his head in confusion.

“There was some idiot intern who flooded the second floor when training their quirk yesterday. The office was cleared out so it can be repaired toda—” A loud crash could be heard from the second floor of the building. Katsuki scowled and started power walking to the second floor while briefly explaining to Izuku (*This is the receptionist desk, that’s the locker room, that’s the pantry*) because he remembered that he’s supposed to be giving Izuku a tour, how sweet.

They finally arrived at Kacchan's destination: A gym, sparring room, and quirk training room all combined into one gigantic room on the second floor of the building. And sure enough, Izuku could faintly hear more sounds coming from the soundproofed room.

“Oi, runt! If I see you here destroying my training room during off-hours one more time, I will send you the repair bills. Got it!?”

“No, you wouldn’t, old man! You can’t just keep bragging that this room has state-of-the-art training equipment better than UA and not let me use it! It’s included in my sidekick contract!” Wait, Izuku knew that voice—

“K-Kota-kun!?”

“Deku-sensei??”

“Sensei!? Kota-kun, are you one of future me’s students?” Izuku clasped his hands around his mouth in awe. “Oh, wow, you’ve grown so much! Did you go to UA’s Hero course? You must, since you’re here as an intern, right? How is interning with Kacchan? It makes sense, since you can apply the concept of his AP shot for your water gun! That’s so amazing! Can you show me, Kota-kun?”

“Uh- what the actual fuck?” To say Kota was flabbergasted was an understatement.

“Language, shitty intern.”

“ *You’re* one to talk!?” Kota yelled indignantly.

“One more written note about how I am a *bad influence* for you, I’m shipping your drenched ass back to Deku’s doorstep.”

“Ri—ght. Anyway, what happened to Deku-sensei? He’s all… shiny and hopeful,” Kota gestured vaguely at Izuku’s direction. Izuku watched the two of them banter back and forth with rapt attention.

“Quirk accident, most probably. This is a Deku from a different time. He’s like, sixteen.”

“He’s my age?? Holy shit… Midoriya-nii!! I missed *you* so much!!” Kota rushed to hug Izuku and frowned when they seemed to be roughly the same height. “Wait, I didn’t remember you being this tiny…”

“You’re exaggerating; the nerd's barely grown ten centimeters after high school, he’s *always* tiny.” Katsuki shoved Kota away and put his hand on Izuku’s shoulder protectively, ignoring Izuku’s embarrassed “Hey!”

Kota wiggled his eyebrows at Kacchan suggestively at the gesture, but Kacchan just sighed and ignored him.

“Anyway, the agency’s being repaired *today,* shitty runt. How the fuck are you here alone!?”

“I…may have…bribed the repair guy to come back later in the day so I can get some more practice in…Hey! Stop hitting me, you grumpy old geezer! It will all be repaired after, anyway! You’ll just get angrier if I destroy the room again *after* it’s been repaired!” Kota was quick to dodge Kacchan’s barrage of explosions and shielded himself with his quirk while running away further into the room.

“Ah, umm…Both of you, maybe we should talk about this calmly?” Izuku suggested. Kacchan and Kota continued to run while blasting

their quirks around the room like a deadlier version of a cat and mouse game, ignoring him.

"Guys!" Blackwhip shot out of his wrists and captured Kota and Kacchan midair in a flash. Both of them turned to look at him, eyes wide.

"S-so cool…Midoriya-nii," Kota's eyes were glistening with unshed tears, and Kacchan, who was casually leaning his body weight against Blackwhip just rolled his eyes and let it gently put him on the ground.

"Kota-kun, I'm not going to reprimand you for wanting to improve on your quirk, but why rush it to the point of making trouble for Kacchan?" Izuku asked gently once Kota was back on the floor and Blackwhip dissipated.

"Well, it's partly your fault too, Midoriya-nii— I mean your older self. He's very… laid back lately, isn't he?" Kota snuck a glance at Kacchan, who just shrugged. "Everyone's been saying that heroes are not needed anymore, so everyone hasn't been trying as hard as back then," he pouted.

"What do you mean, heroes are not needed anymore?" Izuku questioned.

"Apparently crimes had been going down for the last few years, and they must've thought: 'Oh wow! The world is safe now!' Quirk Singularity Doomsday Theory is suddenly not a threat anymore, despite quirks still getting stronger with each new generation. I've experienced it myself, during our class' work study at Uravity's Quirk Counselling Program— it's both amazing and terrifying what those children's quirks can do… So I must prepare myself for any possibilities."

Kota's fingers kept fidgeting when he talked, Izuku noted. What he saw must be really out of this world if he's worrying about it this much.

Izuku turned to Kacchan and asked, "Has society really changed that much?"

Kacchan rolled his eyes in frustration. "Nah, the kid's right. They've gone soft, those peace-loving idiots. If anything, this era felt like a calm before a storm."

"I don't think I can do even a fraction of what you guys could do at sixteen, but Deku-sensei keeps on telling me 'good job' and 'it's okay'. It's so frustrating," Kota lamented. "At least Dynamight's still got it," he made a face at Kacchan, like admitting Dynamight was cool made him feel physical pain.

“Careful runt, one more word from you and I might actually believe that you’re not just here because your beloved Deku-sensei randomly decided so.”

“But I’m the one who put in the application!?” Kota yelled indignantly. “Deku-sensei actually recommended for me to go to Wash, of all heroes!”

“What’s wrong with that? Wash is a solid guy.” Kacchan retorted.

“And your quirks match so well!” Izuku affirmed.

“Well, for starters, I didn’t want to specialize in rescue. My quirk’s better suited for fighting. If I go to Wash, I’ll just be delegated as his sidekick my whole career.” Kota shrugged.

“Mmm, I see. So you chose to go to Kacchan’s instead?” Izuku hummed in understanding.

“Yep! The application almost didn’t go through because he’s an old grump who’s infamous for rejecting sidekick applications, but I have a secret weapon, so here I am!” Kota wiggled his eyebrows again at Kacchan, who flicked Kota’s forehead as hard as he could to make him stop talking.

“Secret weapon?” Izuku wondered.

“Why, it’s your lethal puppy eyes, of cour—hnghhm!” Kacchan covered Kota’s mouth with his entire palm before he could say anything else, but the damage had been done.

“Wha— What are you talking about, Kota-kun?” Izuku blushed.

“That’s it; you’ll call the repair guy, pack up, and go home within five minutes, or I’m terminating your contract.” Kacchan’s threat finally shut Kota up, and he began to begrudgingly pack up his stuff.

“Awww… Just one more hour and I’m done, though. I was so sure you wouldn’t be coming here today, too,” Kota sulked childishly, and Izuku suddenly remembered small Kota from his timeline and got hit with a wave of nostalgia.

“Sorry, Kota-kun, it’s because I want to see Kacchan’s agency once before the quirk is over…”

“Ohoho? Nah, it’s okay, Midoriya-nii, since you kindly just proved my poi—Alright! Alright! I’m going home, geez!” Kota laughed and slung his backpack over his shoulder as Kacchan moved to blast him away again. He gave Izuku one more hug and waved goodbye to the two childhood friends who were still standing near the room’s entrance.

“Stupid, shitty intern… Always saying stupid shit,” Kacchan grumbled under his breath before taking out his phone and messaging the repair team to come immediately.

“It’s good to see you get along well!” Izuku remarked jovially, and Kacchan’s scowl deepened.

“Which part of the conversation just now made you think we got along well!?”

“Well, you accepted him as your intern, for starters,” Izuku shrugged and pulled Kacchan out of the room. Kacchan took it as a sign to continue the tour.

“Worst decision in my fucking life. The agency is built to withstand explosions, not floods.” Kacchan led Izuku to the third floor, and Izuku *ohh-ed* and *ahh-ed* at the spacious office.

“But he’s still here! That’s basically approval in Kacchan Speak. Also, he reminded me of you.”

“That’s hardly a compliment—come over here, nerd.” Izuku followed Kacchan to a private office space at the corner of the floor, clearly reserved for the head position at the agency. It’s a big room

sectioned off from the rest of the office floor and was further split in the middle by an open shelf full of trophies, photos, and other memorabilia. Kacchan led him to the left side of the room, which was decorated in a way that screamed ‘Kacchan!’ with all the black and sleek furniture aesthetic.

Izuku took a glance at the opposite side of the room and found it empty of any decorations except for a lone desk and an office chair. He’s about to ask Kacchan about it before some photos on the shelf caught his interest.

It was an old photo of them showing the ultra-rare All Might cards they just pulled together to the camera, undoubtedly taken by either of their moms. The angle was slightly off, and the card in Kacchan’s hand was blurry because he held it way too close to the lens, but they had such big, matching euphoric grins that Izuku couldn’t help but smile after looking at it.

Remembering this part of their childhood before his quirkless diagnosis eventually drove them apart always filled Izuku with a sense of nostalgia, as well as regrets of what could’ve been. Izuku turned around to find Kacchan watching him silently, and when their eyes met, Izuku knew that Kacchan felt the same way.

Suddenly the empty half of the twin offices made sense, and Izuku felt his heart constrict. It’s relieving to know that Kacchan cherished their memories while growing up together so much. All of his actions ever since Izuku landed in this weird future timeline… everything Kacchan did made Izuku feel so, so loved. There’s no denying that

he was special in Kacchan's eyes, and it was something that Izuku never thought he'd be able to experience.

On the other hand, the action of his future self confused him so much. He was so sure he'd jump at the chance to be Kacchan's hero partner at any point in his life, past, present, or future. *What's changed?* Was the absence of One for All ultimately made them drift apart again, in the end? Was Kacchan and Izuku's relationship ultimately dictated only by the presence or absence of a quirk?

If the twin office and the hero suit were Kacchan's declaration that he wanted Izuku as his hero partner, quirk or not, then it must be his older self who was pulling away with the guise of finding a different calling in teaching, he realized.

"What are you thinking about, looking all like a kicked puppy?" Kacchan's soft voice snapped Izuku out of his train of thoughts.

"I'm scared of losing One for All," Izuku admitted, tears starting to pool at the corner of his eyes. The uneasiness in his stomach grew and grew until he couldn't take it anymore. "I'm scared to lose this gift someday and think I am useless without it," he sobbed harder and lurched forward as Kacchan moved to catch him between his arms. "I'm scared of waking up one day and feeling undeserving of you— I'm so scared that I will just go back to being a useless *Deku* , Kacchan," Izuku hugged Kacchan tightly, and Kacchan was quick to shush him.

"I've told you before— you're *never* useless, Izuku, got it?" Kacchan hugged Izuku back just as fiercely. "Don't give up on your future just yet, Izuku; please tell me you'll still be trying your darndest, quirk or not." Izuku could feel the rumble of Kacchan's shaky breath as he was tucked against his chest.

"Mmmm," Izuku nodded.Being held in Kacchan's arms felt so *right* , Izuku almost didn't realize the ever-present weight on his stomach suddenly *tugged* hard, and he snapped his neck upwards, meeting Kacchan's own teary expression with wide eyes.

What the heck was that!? The vestiges that had been staying respectfully silent for a while were also surprised by the uncomfortable feeling.

I think… It's time to go back . Yoichi's soft voice sent a chill down Izuku's spine.

No, there's still so much I want to say and do here! Izuku thought as he locked eyes with Kacchan, who noticed something from the corner of his eye and gasped at what he found.

Izuku followed Kacchan's gaze and looked down. His hands had started to become translucent. It really was time to go.

“Izuku, I…” Kacchan scrambled to touch any part of Izuku that’s still tangible, but sooner or later his hands just phased through Izuku’s body. Izuku’s heart broke at how Kacchan’s face crumpled.

“Kacchan,” Izuku called as he slowly started to float. He felt like it could fade away any second, so he had to make every second count. “I won’t give up on myself, I promise you. So you shouldn’t give up either, okay?” Izuku reached out his hand to hover against Kacchan’s cheek.

Kacchan subtly leaned into the pseudo-touch. “Just having a chance to share my dream with you again for a moment is more than enough, Izuku; thank you for being here.” Kacchan’s smile was sad and defeated, as if he’s resigned to his fate of never seeing their shared dream come to fruition again.

Izuku hated that look on Kacchan. His symbol of victory shouldn’t look that defeated, surely!

“Don’t you dare give up now that I said I won’t; I’m sure you can knock some sense into my older self’s head! Keep my office clean and ready for me, Kacchan!” Izuku declared.

Kacchan’s stunned expression slowly morphed into his endearing, wobbly smile at Izuku’s words, and Izuku grinned back.

“See you later, Kacchan,” Izuku giggled.

“See you later, Izuku. I love you so, so much.”

Me too, Kacchan! I lo—

Before Izuku could answer Kacchan’s confession properly, his consciousness faded away into nothing.

✦✧

“I’m sorry, I’m so sorry!” Izuku jolted awake by a loud wailing from the side of his…bed. He’s in the hospital; he noticed from the sterile smell and the constant beeping of his heart monitor. He craned his head stiffly to the source of the noise and found a nurse bowing her upper body repeatedly to All Might, who awkwardly tried to reassure her.

“Uh- what happened?” Izuku’s voice came out hoarse and painful against his parched throat, and he let out a series of coughs as All might immediately rushed to his bedside with a glass of water from the bedside table. Huh, he didn’t remember being this parched

before—and famished, too. *Didn't he just have a Katsudon with Kacchan —*

Izuku promptly tried to sit up, ignoring All Might and the nurse's alarmed warning. Memories flooded his brain and sent him reeling. He looked down at his hands and found himself wearing a hospital gown, limbs wrapped in various bandages and casts that were so different from the ones he had before. Huh, Izuku had thought when he crashed he had been transported physically to the future. Or some version of his future.

Was that just a strangely vivid dream?

"Midoriya-shonen, you shouldn't sit up so fast!" All Might warned concernedly. Izuku just looked at him dumbly, still experiencing whiplash from the torrent of memories that felt so real but—

"Oh gosh, I'm so sorry! Please forgive my carelessness; I just worked a very long shift and accidentally used my quirk on you! Hope you didn't see anything too bad…" The nurse from earlier started bowing repeatedly in his direction, and Izuku was too stunned to speak.

"Your…quirk?"

“Yes! My quirk was a clairvoyance type; usually I use them to help the doctors before performing an operation. It enables them to see inauspicious possibilities in the future so they can be more mindful during high-risk procedures,” the nurse warbled through her explanation. She took a tissue from the bedside table, and Izuku thought she’s going to use it on herself, but she used it on him instead.

Huh, he didn’t realize he was crying, too.

“I’m so sorry… Your mental and physical condition were at an all-time low from your injuries and my quirk can be a lot if used without proper preparation— since you can do nothing but watch a terrible version of your life played out in front of you…”

“Eh?” Izuku was once again confused. “Everything felt so real, though…”

“Um, I mean I’ve heard people say that it’s uncanny how detailed it is, and some quirk doctors I’ve gone to in the past had suggested that the realism may come from a possibility that it’s some sort of alternate reality and not just a simple projection—that may be why you can’t interact directly when under the influence of my quirk, though. It’s a mental quirk after all, not a physical one,” the nurse rambled and rambled, and Izuku sat in his hospital bed dumbfounded for a minute before the quirk analyst gear in his brain started spinning at full speed.

Izuku was *sure* he could still taste a lingering flavor of katsudon in his mouth and remember the exact way Kacchan's body touched his when they hugged— all felt *very* tangible. What's the differing factor this time, he wondered. He turned to All Might to ask for his input before he came to a realization.

Was that because I was in the vestiges realm when I got transported? Maybe One for All enhanced the quirk somehow? Does that even make any sense?

He sent a pleading look with his eyes, trying to clue All Might in that he wanted to ask about the vestiges without the nurse hearing about One for All. All Might, bless his heart, took quite a long time to realize Izuku's cryptic series of eye blinks and side eyes before he kindly asked for the nurse to call the doctor to assess Izuku's condition now that he was finally conscious. The nurse bowed one last time before she exited the room hurriedly to call the doctor.

Izuku breathed a sigh he didn't realize he was holding, and All Might sent him a concerned gaze. Before he could begin to recount everything that had happened to him, however, a loud crash could be heard from the hall outside of Izuku's room, accompanied by the familiar voice that Izuku missed more than he realized.

"WHERE'S DEKU? IF THAT IDIOT DIES, I'LL KILL HIM!!!"

Kacchan , Izuku's heart sang. As painful as it might be witnessing his own future self giving up on his dream, talking with a version of future Kacchan who loved him made him think: maybe his once impossible dream wasn't that impossible after all.

Just the thought of it filled him with hope.

I will get everything right this time, Izuku vowed. He promised Kacchan, after all.

✦✧

Chapter End Notes

With this chapter, younger Izuku's part is finished! Originally I wanted to make the timeline merge at the end, but I ultimately decided it's more interesting to separate them. Since younger Izuku got a reality check, he never became Dark Deku and chose to stay at UA. Kacchan's apology was still happening, but in the privacy of their dorm room instead of publicly. They have more time to work on their teamwork better, so Kacchan actually noticed Toga's rope faster and blasted it away before it could take Izuku away this time, and the rest is history!

As for what happened to future Izuku and future Katsuki... stay tuned for the final chapter!

Once again, thank you so much for the kudos and comments; it really keeps me going! Kindly let me know what you think of this chapter, Merry Christmas and Happy holidays!

Edit: I edited my chapter 4 draft and it's already longer than I thought... again. So I'll be splitting it into 2 parts! 10 years of not writing really caught up to me haha, I'll learn how to plan better in the future!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

> "You seemed distracted," Ochako inquired.
>
> Izuku feigned a laugh. "I'm just tired, I guess? Today has been full of surprises."
>
> ✦✧
>
> Or, Ochako and Izuku had a talk.

Chapter Notes

> I edited the tags! Kindly check them before reading! Thank you so much for the kudos and comments~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki unlocked the door to his apartment in silence. Today had been… a lot. If someone told the Katsuki from yesterday that he would be given a chance to meet a version of Izuku who was still shiny-eyed and would do anything to become a hero, Katsuki would've blasted that someone in the face for stating something impossible.

But here he was, and now that he'd been given a taste of what could have been—Izuku sitting across from him in their shared office, Izuku and him training together, fighting together, Izuku drowning in his hoodie, them sharing a bowl of Katsudon and chatting their day away—he's not sure if he could function without him again.

Shit, and he's doing so well, too. Pathetic.

Katsuki wordlessly strode to his bathroom and started peeling off his clothes to shower. Then, he caught his reflection in the mirror.

Who am I kidding? Katsuki sighed, his gaze running across the scars adorning his entire upper body—the starburst scar in the middle of his chest and the long, jagged ones covering almost his entire right arm in particular.

I'm sorry…Is it because I wasn't there? Younger Izuku's shaky voice echoed in his head.

"You idiot," Katsuki scolded his reflection in the mirror. He couldn't even find the right words to answer the question. Not when all of his scars were made in Izuku's name, and the thing was, he's so damn proud of every single one of them. The scars proved he protected him, that even Shigaraki fucking Tomura thought Katsuki was special enough for Izuku to lose control over seeing him hurt.

Maybe once upon a time, he was special to Izuku, indeed.

Katsuki sluggishly finished showering and immediately crashed on his bed. Part of him wished the quirk was kind enough to let the

timeline merge and he'd woken up to a version of Izuku who'd never given up on him in his bed, but the other part of him knew it was just wishful thinking. He could only wish for the younger him from the other timeline to not mess it up and for Izuku to never lose his spark so he could continue being the best hero Katsuki knew he was in that timeline.

Don't you dare give up now that I said I won't! Again, younger Izuku's words gripped around Katsuki's broken heart like a vice. After trying—failing—to let go all this time, was it still okay for him to dream? Would his Izuku—not his, his mind supplied—still want what Katsuki's offering? What if he just made them drift even more apart by trying?

Like a divine intervention from the universe, his phone pinged. Katsuki almost didn't want to check it, but when he did, his heart almost burst out of his chest again.

Uraraka

Katsuki, it's Izuku. Is my younger self still there?

Katsuki almost threw his phone against the wall after reading the display name before remembering that the nerd's phone was smashed to smithereens earlier in the day. He took a deep breath in an attempt to calm his heart. He's being childish, he chastised himself. No need to get worked up every time Cheeks was mentioned; that's unfair for her.

Katsuki typed and untyped his answer several times, suddenly very aware that this was the first time Izuku reached out to Katsuki with a non-business/ internship matter in almost a year—wait, did this even count as one?

Get a fucking grip, Katsuki berated himself before finally sending his reply:

Katsuki

Nah, quirk's over. He's back to where he came from.

Uraraka

Oh… That's glad to hear. Thank you for stopping by today to help, Katsuki.

Katsuki

Don't sweat it.

I'd do anything for any version of you, Katsuki had no trouble admitting it to himself from the comfort of his bed, but in front of Izuku, he'd never trust himself not to say the wrong thing. So he always thought showing it with his actions was enough. He just realized far too late that it's not enough.

Katsuki watched the small dots at the bottom corner of his phone screen blink for quite some time, indicating that Izuku was still typing. After what felt like hours, Katsuki's breath hitched at what Izuku typed.

Uraraka

Are you free tomorrow?

Katsuki's heart did a somersault in his chest cavity. He rushed to sit on his bed and reread the message over and over to make sure he didn't read it wrong. Then he remembered that Izuku was texting him using his *girlfriend's phone.* How deluded could he be?

Uraraka

I'd like for us to catch up, maybe over dinner?

Izuku's next text caught Katsuki off-guard. *Okay, okay* —Katsuki took a deep breath. Had this kind of message been sent last week, Katsuki would've ignored it for months until it was way too awkward to reply. But after today's event, Katsuki was eager to reach out to whatever olive branch Izuku offered him.

Don't you dare give up now that I said I won't!

I won't, Izuku, I won't. Katsuki typed his response with shaky hands.

Katsuki

Sure. Meet me at Aoi-san's at 7, the usual table.

Uraraka

Okay! See you, Kacchan!

Imeabf Kstuki

I mean Katsuki

Sorry

See you tomorrow!

That's it—Katsuki's dead and had gone to heaven. What the fuck was that, honestly? Was that damn nerd even aware of what he had done to Katsuki's heart? (The answer was no, or else they wouldn't be in this situation.)

Katsuki

K.

Katsuki replied curtly before throwing his phone at his nightstand and smothering his face with his pillow. *Okay, game plan,* Katsuki thought after shouting to his pillow to calm himself down. He's not going to burden Izuku with his unnecessary feelings—he kept remembering younger Izuku's eyes lighting up and his wide, teary smile right before he vanished when Katsuki said he loved him.

Knowing that there's a version of Izuku who loved him back was enough, he kept telling himself over and over again. He'd just come to catch up with Izuku tomorrow, be happy for him when the inevitable 'gushing about Cheeks like an idiot in love' part of the conversation happened, and maybe if he's feeling selfish enough, he'd ask him to patrol together again someday soon. And if—and only if—this went well, he'd ask Izuku about joining his agency again in the future.

He owed Izuku's younger self this, at the very least. No more running away.

Katsuki tossed and turned in his bed for what seemed like hours. Sleep seemed to elude him in the wake of this very eventful day. After what felt like eternity, Katsuki gave up and sat up on his bed again. He looked around and cringed at the overall state of his apartment. He'd been throwing himself into work these past few months, and it seemed that his apartment took the brunt of it. Dirty laundry was strewn carelessly everywhere, and his nightstand and bed headboard were gathering dust. Katsuki forced himself to stand up to catalog the state of his apartment.

One proper look at his bathroom floor was enough to send Katsuki reeling. It was *way* worse than he thought. He glanced at the digital clock on his nightstand.

02:12 AM

Oh well, nothing beats power cleaning at 2 AM to get your life back together, right?

✦✧

Izuku and Ochako cleaned up their apartment after Katsuki and Younger Izuku left.

Izuku felt jittery and unfocused. His mind was running everywhere. He tried desperately to stop thinking about Katsuki—about how his younger self was acting when he found out they were no longer close. He didn’t realize he'd been sweeping on the same spot for minutes until Ochako called him out of his thoughts.

“You seemed distracted,” she inquired.

Izuku feigned a laugh. “I’m just tired, I guess? Today has been full of surprises.”

Ochako accepted his half-baked explanation with a hum and continued her ramble while taking out the remains of their coffee table with her quirk. Izuku didn’t pay attention to her before, only realizing now that she’d been complaining about Katsuki.

“How could he ghost us for months but act as if nothing happened when he came by today?” Ochako pouted when putting out the last of the big wood chunks into a trash bag.

Izuku stopped his sweeping. ”Maybe he’s just busy,” Izuku said dismissively. By the time he finished sweeping every nook and cranny of their apartment for stray splinters, the sun had already gone down the horizon, casting a blue tone over their apartment.

”But only for us! I saw him a few weeks ago hanging out with Kirishima-kun and the others just fine,” Ochako huffed as she began to prepare a simple dinner for both of them. She then looked over at him worriedly, “Are you…Alright, with both of you drifting apart? Seeing the younger you today made me remember how attached you were to him in high school.”

“I thought—with everything that happened… We’re in the way of becoming closer,” his younger self’s confession kept replaying in his head over and over.

”It’s alright; friends drifted apart all the time,” he echoed the very words he said to his younger self this afternoon. “We still see each other when he guest teaches at UA or during Kota’s internship report…” Izuku trailed off while taking out the tableware; the plates clinked against one another as they slipped out of his grasp for a split second before he steadied his hands again.

Ochako raised her eyebrow at Izuku, unconvinced. Soon, the familiar smell of Ochako’s fried rice filled the space within their apartment, and Izuku took a deep breath to ground himself in its familiarity.

”I’m truly okay with it, ‘Chako,” Izuku tried to laugh it off. “Besides, I spend all my time with you, anyway, so it’s not like I’m lonely,” Izuku winked at her playfully, and Ochako rolled her eyes at him in exasperation but smiled nonetheless.

Izuku strode to their cupboard to take out some instant miso soup packages. It’s very handy during the nights when they’re too tired to cook and need something quick and warm for dinner.

”Speaking about friends drifting apart, I wonder why we lose contact for a while after graduating UA?” Ochako wondered out loud while serving her simple fried rice into two plates.

Izuku stopped dead in his tracks in the middle of opening the soup package, causing its freeze-dried content to drop to the floor unceremoniously. “Ah — haha, oops, I think my hands are acting up again,” he made a point by putting on a show, waving his scarred hand in Ochako's direction.

“Izuku-kun, something is clearly bothering you,” Ochako gently clasped his hand in hers before continuing, “You know you can always tell me anything, right?”

Izuku swallowed the bile that was threatening to rise from his throat and put out his usual, practiced smile. “I’m just hungry! Let’s — let’s eat first, okay?”

Ochako wasn’t willing to let it go. “Fine, but we’ll talk after dinner, okay? Don’t even think of running away,” she pointed the electric kettle at him before pouring some hot water into the instant miso soup in the bowl and finishing setting up their humble dinner.

As dinner went by in stifled silence, Izuku cursed his younger self’s sudden, unannounced visit for making a box of memories he tried so hard to repress resurface from the corner of Izuku’s mind . Furthermore, Ochako’s earlier question was the final trigger that blasted the box wide open with no hope of ever getting closed again.

They finished dinner, and Izuku convinced Ochako to let him wash the dishes because she already cooked for them. He was just delaying the inevitable, of course, but as he finished drying the last of the plates, he still didn't know what to say.

Ochako had prepared two glasses of tea and placed them on a small stool near the sofa as a makeshift coffee table. Izuku trudged to the sofa like a man walking to his own execution, and once they were sitting eye to eye on the sofa, Izuku began by saying a simple, "I'm sorry."

"For what?" Ochako tilted her head to the side. Now that every memory Izuku tried to move on from was out in the forefront of his mind, it felt like going from blindness to 20/20 vision. Izuku's eyes watched as Ochako's twin hair buns bounced along with her movement, and he berated himself for being so blinded by his own delusion that he never made a connection to the familiar hairstyle.

"For not being truthful, I suppose," Izuku took his tea mug and held it between his hands, watching his reflection on the surface of the tea as the warmth seeped from the mug to his scarred palms. It felt like the comfort he needed to finally let the words out. "I think I'm the reason why we drifted apart after graduation," he confessed. *It's the same way I'm the reason Katsuki and I drifted apart; I'm a coward, I'm sorry.*

"What do you mean?" Ochako frowned, clearly not expecting the question she asked out of light curiosity to be the reason Izuku got so shaken up.

“Today’s got me thinking too much about the past,” Izuku admitted finally. His hand shook so much he decided to put down his tea mug after taking a sip. “Do you remember, in the winter of our third year, when we were talking about…what we were going to do in the future after graduation?”

“Yeah? I think it’s the first time I told you about the idea of starting a Quirk Counselling Program to honor Himiko-chan’s name, right?”

Izuku nodded stiffly before continuing. No backing out now, he supposed. “You said to me that seeing her smiling while confessing her feelings for me at Okuto Island left a lasting impression on you — ”

“Yes, what did that have to do with anything, though?” Ochako started to fidget uncomfortably on the sofa. “You’re not — you’re not jealous, are you?” Ochako let out a chuckle to lighten up the situation, but Izuku remained stiff as a board.

“Then you said that, um, that you were actually glad… That she brought me over to the island for that to happen,” Izuku finished, eyes starting to sting with unshed tears.

Ochako still looked at him weirdly, like she didn’t understand the grim implication of her own statement.

“Ochako, because of that, he — ” The first tear fell before Izuku could even finish his sentence. He took a few ragged breaths and let Ochako pull his hands into hers in a silent show of support. “Because Toga pulled me to Okuto Island… Kacchan was dead, Ochako, and I was too far away to help him — ” And the dam just…broke. Izuku let himself overtaken by grief for the first time in forever, sobbing and trembling not unlike how his younger counterpart cried over Katsuki a few hours ago.

Ochako pulled Izuku into a tight embrace, mouthing sorry over and over. “Oh, gods, I’m so sorry, Izuku-kun, that’s not what I meant — ” She rubbed his back over and over again as he cried on her shoulder.

“I — I didn’t know how to act around you after that, so — so I just disappeared the moment I could. I’m so sorry, Ochako, it was all my fault.” Izuku's stuttered apology was muffled by Ochako’s shoulder, and she could feel her shoulder start to dampen with tears.

“No, Izuku-kun, it was my fault! I’m so sorry I made you shoulder that alone all these years.” Ochako was starting to tear up, too. “I just threw myself into work right after graduation and didn’t spare any time to check on you too.”

Izuku shook his head. He felt bad for telling Ochako the reason, but could no longer keep it to himself.

“Say, Izuku-kun,” Ochako lifted his face from her shoulder gently so they were face to face. “Is there any particular reason you only remembered this today?” She asked tentatively. Izuku immediately averted her gaze, and that told Ochako all she needed to know.

“Did you avoid Bakugou-kun for similar reasons? Did he hurt you?”

“No!” Izuku denied vehemently. He couldn’t admit to Ochako that he’s the one who did it on purpose; he forced Katsuki to stop reaching out to him because Izuku felt undeserving. Rejecting his offer, never patrolling with him, keeping him at an arm's length because…

Because the moment he got the suit, he was so scared he’d get pulled into Kacchan’s orbit again and started enjoying hero work too much.

He didn’t deserve to have *fun* being an active hero again.

“You’ve got the wrong idea, Ochako; it’s not like that — I…” Izuku couldn’t think of any more excuses to say at this point.

Ochako looked contemplative, her brows furrowed together and mouth pulled into a frown. She quietly let go of Izuku and asked him

again, “Then, do you have feelings for Bakugou-kun, Izuku-kun?”

“What!? How did you — how can you come up with that conclusion, Ochako? I’m in a relationship with you!” *No,* Izuku desperately wanted to say. But he couldn’t straight-up deny it for some reason. There’s no way, right? Katsuki was his childhood friend; he’d know if he had feelings for him, right? *Oh—OH!*

“You — you mean like, platonically, right? He’s my important childhood friend — ”

“No, Izuku-kun, I’m asking — are you in love with Bakugou-kun?” Ochako’s voice was firm as she repeated the question, eyes pleading. Izuku couldn’t answer. This was not how he imagined this conversation would go.

“Why does this have to do with anything?”

Ochako started sobbing for real this time, mirroring Izuku's state just a minute ago. Izuku was taken aback, taking her hands into his and starting to gently rub his thumb against her palm in an attempt to comfort her.

“Because it would make everything about you make sense, wouldn’t it?” Ochako warbled. “And oh, Izuku-kun…I think I haven’t been

truthful with you, too — I'm so, *so sorry…"* She took her hands away from his hold and clasped them around her mouth.

"Truth was, on the night we decided to talk more — Himiko's been appearing in my dreams for a while, telling me to live my life the way I wanted. Himiko-chan and I used to have this crush on you all those years ago, you know? So when you asked me out, I — I think I was sort of projecting a little when I said yes — I thought our mutual crush for you was the only thing still connecting us together now that she's no longer alive…" Ochako hid her face behind her hands in shame as she continued to sob.

"I — I don't get it, Ochako…"

"Izuku-kun, the reason we drifted apart and reconnected was never driven by our own desire for each other, but it was dictated by the presence of our most important persons; I realize that now," Ochako's eyes were pleading for Izuku to understand, and slowly, Izuku could feel the house of cards he desperately built for the sake of appearances crumbling away into nothing.

"When I reached out to you that day, it's really me who wanted to talk to you — "

"Can you really vouch for that, Izuku-kun? Was there really no other reason?"

As if on cue, Izuku started to remember his conversation with Katsuki and Kirishima in Katsuki's car before they arrived at the dinner that changed everything.

Oh no. Izuku looked at Ochako in horror as realization dawned upon him, and Ochako nodded, fully expecting it to happen.

"Oh, no, Ochako *—I'm such a despicable person—* I'm…I remember rejecting Katsuki's offer to join his agency like it was nothing, and I felt so, so awful about it — "

"So you reached out to me," Ochako finished matter-of-factly, without judgment.

"Ochako, I'm so sorry — I messed up real bad; you d-deserve better."

Ochako shook her head. "We did this to each other, Izuku-kun. I'm also so, so sorry for letting it come this far."

"Back then I also thought that… we were inevitable since we share the same pain and the same remorse. But that's not true at all, is it?" Izuku asked, despite already knowing the answer.

“Both of us failed to save someone we desperately wanted to save; that much is true.” Ochako took a sip of her now cooled down tea in an attempt to compose herself. “The rest of the world celebrated their death, while we’re stuck here mourning and cursing our own failures. But that’s where our similarities end.”

“All these years, I’ve lived my life trying to honor Himiko-chan’s name. I see her face in every child who joined my counseling program and prayed no child will ever have to experience what she’s experienced.”

“Everything I do is for her,” she concluded. Rather than feeling betrayed, Izuku’s bleeding heart went out to her. It must’ve been hard. He initially thought Ochako and he shared the same pain regarding the people they failed to save, but they couldn’t be more different. All Izuku felt regarding Tenko was guilt and shame from failing to live up to his expectations; meanwhile, what Ochako had for Toga was pure love.

“I — I really admire you for that, Ochako,” Izuku smiled shakily through his tears. “All I have done these past 9 years is running away.”

“I think you gave yourself too little credit, Izuku-kun. Your work as a teacher is nothing to scoff at, you know?”

Izuku let out a deep sigh. “But I — ”

“Say, Izuku-kun. Are you happy… this past year and a half with me?” Ochako propped her chin on her palms and leaned forward into Izuku’s space.

“Of course I am, Ochako — ”

“But do I make you the happiest?” She asked again, and Izuku’s breath got caught in his throat.

“I — I don’t understand what you mean, Ochako. Is there a difference?”

“Ugh — stop deflecting for one second! You know what I meant. I thought we were having an honest conversation with each other?” Ochako slapped Izuku’s thigh lightly in reprimand.

“I don’t think I even deserve to be happy… after everything that happened,” Izuku admitted resignedly.

“And who gets to decide who deserves what? Izuku-kun, this guilt you’re carrying… It's not healthy. I had a feeling you’d been acting weird since you started pulling back from hero patrol, but… I didn’t

know it was this bad for you. I'm so sorry for not noticing sooner," Ochako reached out to hold Izuku's hand like he did all those years ago on the cliff when she was grieving over Himiko's death.

"I think… You need to talk to Bakugou-kun," Ochako suggested softly.

Piercing red eyes gazing down at him while the owner was holding his younger self's body so delicately flashed through Izuku's mind. And immediately after that, the same eyes were gray and lifeless. Suddenly Izuku was back in the coffin in the sky and was helpless to do anything.

"No!" Izuku jerked his hands away from Ochako and curled into himself.

"Please — listen to me, Izuku-kun… I've come to realize that… All this time you've been putting Bakugou-kun and your ideal heroism on the same pedestal, and because you felt undeserving of being a hero, you're pulling away from the person most important to you to punish yourself."

"But you can't keep doing that to yourself, Izuku-kun. D-do you know that I would give up anything to be able to talk to Himiko-chan again? I would sell my soul in a *heartbeat* just for a chance to hold her hand again," Ochako's shoulders were trembling as she

confessed. “Call me selfish all you want, but these are my true feelings.”

“Ochako, you’re the least selfish person I know,” Izuku replied back instinctively. “I think it’s alright to be selfish once in a while; after all, you — ” Izuku was interrupted by the sound of Ochako’s laugh.

“ *You* of all people should *really* learn how to practice what you preach,” Ochako giggled at Izuku’s offended pout. “See, Izuku-kun, this is why I want you to talk to Bakugou-kun. For us, given how similar we are to each other, we’ll just end up running in circles giving advice we can’t even take to heart.”

“But — I don’t think he even wanted to talk to me anymore,” Katsuki’s earlier goodbye still echoed in Izuku’s head. His body shuddered, but not from the cold.

“But he came for you, today.”

“Not for me.”

“I called him saying you’re in trouble and was asking for you without specifying which *you* I was talking about,” Ochako reassured Izuku with a nod. “He came for you, Izuku-kun.”

Izuku was speechless at the revelation. Even after he tried so hard to keep Katsuki at arm's length at the expense of his own heart, Katsuki was still…

"Stop running away from yourself, Izuku-kun. You should cherish what you hold most dear to your heart when he's still here, alive and breathing," Ochako hugged Izuku for the final time. Both of them knew that when they let go of each other, things between them would never be the same again.

"Oh, Ochako — I'm so sorry, this is so *unfair* for you — You're also precious to me; please believe me!"

"You're also precious to me, Izuku-kun, that's why now that I understand… I want you to chase your own happiness," Ochako pressed a feather-light kiss to Izuku's hair, and he sobbed even more.

"Before you start blaming yourself again, Izuku-kun, please remember that we're only human. We made mistakes, we talked and acknowledged it, and then we learned from it. There's no shame in that. I think… Today is good for us. I feel like I understand you better today than I ever did the entire time we knew each other."

Surprisingly, Izuku was the one who broke the hug. His emerald eyes were shiny with tears, and Ochako knew the messy state of his

face mirrored her own. “Thank you, ‘Chako. I — I’m done running away.”

“Does this mean we’ll be seeing more of Hero Deku in the field soon?” She teased.

Izuku groaned and put his head in his hands.

“Too fast, huh? I’ll let Bakugou-kun handle that one, then.” Ochako stood up and patted Izuku’s head consolingly before taking the cooled-off tea to the kitchen sink. “You’ll contact him, right?”

“Mmhmm,” Izuku hummed noncommittally. Ochako rolled her eyes.

“C’mon now — Oh! I know! What if you text him right now to ask if younger you are still with him to start the conversation?” Ochako clasped her hands together and Izuku panicked.

“Now!? Isn’t it too soon —*Wait,* my phone is broken! You can’t force me to — ”

Ochako took out her own phone and grinned. “Well, he knows your phone is broken, so I can just text him from mine.”

“Wha — No, Ochako!” Izuku ran from his seat on the sofa to where Ochako was in the kitchen, typing something on her phone. They chased after each other around the dinner table for a minute before Izuku caught Ochako and took her phone away from her grasp, with her giggling in his hold.

Izuku let her go and paled when he saw the phone screen. Ochako was so close to sending Katsuki a message, and he immediately rushed to delete it. But then, his trembling hands accidentally clicked send instead.

“Oh no, no, no…” Izuku hadn’t even finished voicing his panic when Katsuki immediately replied. “Oh! Uh, Katsuki said he’s already gone.” *What now?*

Ochako beamed at him, but stayed silent.

“You’re not going to help me after setting me up? Mean…” Izuku pouted and focused his attention back to the phone, trying to start a conversation without seeming too eager. Ochako watched him flail pathetically for a minute and immediately lit up again when Katsuki replied. Then he let out a squeak and started typing really quickly before almost throwing the phone away and stopped when he remembered it’s not his phone.

“Noooooooo… Ochako, can you *please* use your quirk to launch me to space, please…” Izuku returned Ochako’s phone to her and sat on the floor with his head between his knees in shame.

Ochako confusedly checked the texts on her phone, and started cackling after she finished going through them. “That’s actually so cute, Izuku-kun!”

“Stop it, please…”

“This can easily be avoided if you just continue calling him *Kacchan* ,”

“But isn’t it… childish? We’ve already passed our mid-twenties…”

“Growing up doesn’t mean you have to be a boo — ring adult, Izuku-kun!” Ochako poked Izuku’s cheeks while pouting at the mention of age.

“Yeah, yeah,” Izuku gave in. He contemplated for a while before saying softly, “Thank you for everything, Ochako.”

“Mmhmm, I actually missed us bantering as friends more than I thought. So this is…nice, actually.”

"Yeah?"

"Yeah. Just don't ghost me again after this, okay?"

"I'd never dream of it, Ochako; you're still one of my closest friends."

Ochako beamed and clasped her hand. "It's getting late, so we should clean up and sleep. Izuku-kun, you can shower first while I finish cleaning up!"

"Okay, 'Chako." Now that the tension was gone completely, Izuku let out a yawn and started to sway on his way to the bathroom. Guess he's going to crash out soon.

Izuku carelessly tossed his dirty clothes in the laundry basket before he heard the sound of something dropping to the ground. Izuku refocused his sleepy eyes to search for the source of the sound, only to find a ring box lying on the ground; it must have fallen out of his pocket when he tossed it away.

Oh my god, Izuku had completely forgotten about the existence of the ring! This morning felt so long ago now, and looking back at it, he thanked whatever blip in the universe that had allowed for his younger self to literally crash his stupid, misguided plan. He hoped

Ochako would never find out about this; else he would never hear the end of it.

Izuku’s thoughts circled back to Katsuki, as they always did. He had no idea how tomorrow’s dinner would go, but he prayed that it’s not too late for them to finally be on the same page.

Please, Kacchan. Can I still be a hero…with you?

✦✧

Chapter End Notes

I finished this chapter half asleep right during new year because the fireworks were too loud and I couldn't sleep. I hope this is passable... Platonic Izuocha is so dear to me!!!

Please let me know what you think of this chapter!
Happy New Year everyone!!!

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Izuku was special to Kacchan; that's the undeniable truth.

But what about Izuku?

Chapter Notes

Sorry for the long wait, and thank you so much for the kudos and comments!!

Please enjoy the ride~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Izuku-kun!"

Izuku was shaken awake by the sound of Ochako's voice. "Wha — ?" He mumbled groggily. He chose to sleep on the sofa after last night to avoid awkwardness, but the moment he woke up to a sore back and stiff neck, he almost regretted it immediately.

"First of all, I'm sorry for going through your things — I just want to borrow a pen, I swear! But I…found this?" Ochako sounded so confused and apologetic, and Izuku forced his eyes to stay open to look at the thing Ochako pushed into his line of sight.

To his horror, his eyes were immediately greeted by the sight of the ring box he swore he had hidden in the bottom of his work bag to be

returned to the store as soon as he was able.

"I — uhhhh…" His brain short-circuited. So much for keeping it a secret.

"Well?"

"I, um. I was actually… planning to propose to you yesterday… before my younger self crashed into the coffee table?" Izuku grimaced at his own confession.

Ochako's jaw hung open at the realization. "What!?" She looked at the ring box for a moment before turning her gaze back to him. He felt small under her gaze suddenly, so he sank further into the sofa. "Isn't that too soon? We — we're not even on a first-name basis until five months ago!"

"I — well, I *thought* that we were getting along well, and we're not getting younger, you know?"

"We've never even been… *intimate* with each other!"

"Didn't we sleep on the same bed?" Izuku was confused.

"Well — don't couples usually do *—I don't know—* more?" Ochako blushed and flailed her arms around trying to get her point across.

"I thought… maybe you're waiting until marriage? You never initiated things with me, so I thought —"

" *You* never initiated things with me, Izuku-kun! I initiated almost everything we did as a couple, but you're always too busy for dates and stuff," Ochako huffed.

It was Izuku's turn to be surprised. Had he really been that inattentive as a boyfriend? "In my mind I thought we're just… comfortable with each other, you know? Like with living together and stuff —"

"Like a roommate, you mean?" Ochako interjected. "When was the last time we even kissed?" She challenged.

"Uhh… yesterday?"

"A peck on the cheek didn't count! And you know that's platonic!"

“Huh…” Izuku looked like a deer caught up in the headlights. His mind came up with nothing.

“This is too big of a leap to take when we haven’t even discussed anything remotely similar to this, you know?” Ochako took a seat beside Izuku on the sofa, who was feeling all kinds of mortifying thoughts right now. “And though I *do* feel comfortable with you, I have to admit the spark is just not there, you know? So —” She narrowed her eyes at him, suddenly suspicious.

“Hang on… Who put the idea to propose in your head?”

“No one, I swear!” Izuku reflexively replied but shrank under Ochako’s gaze. “Uh… some of the Gen Eds teachers were talking about it, and they said that twenty-five is the ideal age to settle down and get married…”

“In what universe?? Did they say that to you specifically?” Ochako made a face, it’s unbelievable that someone in their age range still held such an outdated view, and that Izuku fell for it so easily.

“Well — I was there, and they kept looking at me pointedly. So I thought…uh, maybe I should… get… married… soon…” Izuku trailed off, face getting warmer in shame.

Ochako got up from the sofa to snatch her phone from the dining table and started to type furiously.

"I want names," she demanded.

"W-what for?" Izuku stammered at her sudden request.

"Just, do you remember who said that and looked at you funny?" She pressed further, and Izuku hesitated before answering.

"Uh… it was Terada-sensei…"

Ochako continued to type on her phone furiously.

Izuku watched her for a moment, confused. "Who are you texting?"

"Todoroki-kun," Ochako answered curtly. She hit the send button with a dramatic tap before turning to smile sweetly at Izuku, who shivered.

"W-what for?"

“He’s going to be your guest teacher next week, right? I just texted to tell him about a certain someone who might appreciate having an ice floor to skate around in their office." There's a rare mischievous glint in Ochako’s brown eyes as she laid out her plan with an uncharacteristically innocent tone.

“Ochako!? That’s mean!”

“Well, she needs to learn how to mind her own business! Imagine if yesterday didn’t happen, Izuku-kun; would you go through with the idea?”

“I — yeah…maybe?”

“And yesterday’s me would’ve- — oh, *shoot,* I would’ve accepted it!” Ochako stopped mid-rant to cover her face with her hands. “We’ll be miserable in a few years when we inevitably find out the truth about each other! Our issues… are not something you can just erase with a ring, you know.”

“I…know that now. I’m sorry, Ochako.”

“I’m not mad at you. I’m also — I think I also would go through with it for the same reason as yours.” Ochako took Izuku's face between

her palms, dutifully keeping her pinky raised as usual so she didn't accidentally float him away.

"Just… learn how to communicate better, and don't listen to other people's standards about how your life should be, okay? It's your life to live, Izu-kun, not theirs."

"Mmhmm," Izuku hung his head low the moment Ochako let go of him.

"Okay, we should probably get ready for work, then. Are you planning to return this?" Ochako handed the ring box over to Izuku.

"Yeah, I'll return it on the weekend when I'm going to buy a new phone." Izuku accepted the box and put it in his pajama pants pocket immediately, unable to look at it any second longer.

"Oh yeah — I almost forgot about that. Isn't it dangerous though? You should buy a new phone as soon as possible!" Ochako suggested.

"It'll be fine. I need all the extra time on the weekdays to grade my students' papers, especially since I'm already so behind because of yesterday." Izuku scratched his head sheepishly.

Oh — I won't keep you here any longer then; you can still make it to your office early if you get ready now . Sorry for waking you up so suddenly!"

"It's alright! I'll see you tonight?" Izuku smiled, feeling lighter than ever.

"Are you sure you're not going to spend the night at Bakugou-kun's?" Ochako raised her eyebrows suggestively at Izuku.

"W —*w* e're just going to talk at a restaurant!" Izuku immediately went beet red. What was she even talking about? Izuku was lucky Katsuki even wanted to talk to him after everything. It's not like they would —

"Sure, sure~" Ochako sing-songed while walking to the kitchen to prepare some breakfast, leaving Izuku alone to deal with his increasingly embarrassing thoughts.

✦✧

Izuku glanced at the clock the moment he stepped into the teacher's office. Good… he still had about thirty-five minutes left before

homeroom started to grade his students' papers. He set down his work bag and his hero suit at the feet of his desk, stacked all the ungraded paper to one side, and began to go through the papers before the office was busy with the arrival of other teachers.

About five minutes in, however, he could hear the sound of the office door sliding open. He thought it might be one of the teachers (but definitely not Aizawa, because he always arrived fashionably late), but then he heard a whispered ' *shit'* coming from the direction of the door. Izuku immediately looked up and locked eyes with Kota, who looked like a kid who just got caught with one hand inside the cookie jar.

"Kota-kun?" He called before Kota could quietly close the door and bolted away, and the boy grinned sheepishly at him. "What are you doing this early in the morning?"

"I thought there's no one in the office at this hour…" He admitted. "Uh, I just wanted to submit my internship update report early?"

"Homeroom is in half an hour; why can't you just wait until then?"

"Well, uh… I just want to *hopefully* hand the report over discreetly — "

“What did you do, Kota-kun?” Izuku narrowed his eyes suspiciously at Kota’s antics. He interned with Katsuki, didn’t he? Did something happen?

“Huh — Dynamight didn’t tell you?” It was Kota’s turn to look apprehensive. “So it was true… Do you guys not talk to each other anymore?”

Izuku was taken aback by the question, and, he had to admit, reacted a little bit defensively. “We’re just… busy, Kota-kun. We’re adults with adult jobs after all.”

“Yeah, right,” Kota scrunched up his nose at Izuku’s reasoning. “No wonder Dynamight is cranky all the time… Deku-sensei is just too oblivious…” He whispered seemingly to himself, but Izuku heard him loud and clear.

“What does that mean, Kota-kun!?”

“Uhh — I may or may not have met your younger self with Dynamight yesterday… At the agency.” Kota admitted.

“And how does this have anything to do with your report?” Izuku tried his best to look put together, but inside his brain was running with thousands of questions. Katsuki brought his younger self to his

agency? What for? How come Katsuki never asked Izuku to visit his office? What's it like? Would Katsuki let Izuku come, had he asked?

"N-nothing! — *It's just that they looked very affectionate with each other yesterday. I couldn't help but root for my mentor, hoping that it would get him to stop acting so grouchy every time I broke his training room!"* Kota mumbled too low and fast for Izuku to catch anything besides 'each other,' 'root for my mentor,' and 'training.' Izuku raised his eyebrow at that. Did Katsuki bring his younger self to his agency to…spar? Why he'd never — was it because his younger self still had One for All?

There's an unfamiliar feeling churning deep in his guts, and Izuku didn't like how he felt his chest constricted at the mere thought of Katsuki grinning and sparring with the version of himself that could still keep up with him. *You have no right,* Izuku chastised himself. *Not when you're the one who pulled away.*

" — Anyway, here's my report! Please don't fail my internship, Deku-sensei! I'm actually making progress, I swear!" Kota put down his report before running for the door. Just before he exited the office, however, he stopped and looked back.

Silence stretched across the room for a moment before Kota finally opened his mouth to talk, his gaze locked with Izuku's own.

"Midoriya-nii, you're a really good teacher, you know?"

“Huh?” Izuku was taken aback by the sudden earnestness in Kota’s voice.

“But I think — we all thought….” Kota stumbled upon his sentences for a second before continuing. “Mmhmm, nevermind. It’s just… I think you’re an even cooler hero.”

“Yeah?” Izuku let his mouth curl upward to a slight smile.

“The *coolest* . My favorite hero of all time, remember?” Kota gestured to his red sneakers and quickly shut the door and ran off before Izuku could respond. Izuku sat at his desk dazedly, trying to digest Kota’s words for a minute before the door to the office opened again. This time Cementoss was the one who opened it, and Izuku quickly greeted his former teacher and current coworker before bringing his attention back to his desk.

Izuku tried hard to focus on his task, but his thoughts were all over the place. He was so focused on trying to focus he didn’t even realize it was time for homeroom until the bell rang and jolted him out of his seat. He quickly gathered his stuff and, with one last sigh after looking at the stack of ungraded papers, ran to the direction of his classroom.

Stay focused, Izuku; you have a class to teach.

✦✧

Izuku let out a relieved sigh the moment he made it back to the teacher's office. He managed to get through the first half of the day in one piece, despite his mind not being into it for the first time in months. *Maybe I'm just tired,* he thought while pinching the bridge of his nose, trying to keep the headache that had been steadily creeping in at bay.

He silently unwrapped the onigiri he had purchased earlier, opting for convenience instead of a proper meal from Lunch Rush so he could continue to work. He had no time to waste; his students deserved the best, after all. He took great pride in his analytic ability, even though it started as an outlet for his younger self to daydream what it'd be like to have a quirk, but it proved to be a useful asset to have as a hero and a teacher. And all of his students would know something was up if he suddenly wrote too short a feedback, so he'd just have to grit his teeth and do his best to finish the whole thing today.

And then tonight he would have dinner with Katsuki with no more work looming over his head. That's one less thing to worry about. Izuku could work with that.

He took small bites of the onigiri and chewed while he continued to write. He smiled a little bit whenever his students got some interesting details in their analysis. They'd truly grown so much.

Izuku took another bite of his onigiri when Aizawa walked past his desk and backtracked to ask him, "Onigiri again, problem child?"

"Aizawa-san! You surprised me. Yeah, I was behind in my work, so I went for convenience today;" he's waving his onigiri in his left hand and his pen in his right hand to explain his point.

"You've always opted for 'convenience' these days, even though you used to bring very elaborate lunches before. What happened?"

Izuku blinked confusedly for a moment before realizing that Katsuki used to bring Izuku lunch whenever the blond had some leftovers from dinner. Back then Katsuki was in his experimental cooking era, so such occurrences were common. Unsurprisingly, it stopped around a year ago when Izuku, under the weight of stress and expectations, pulled away from their friendship.

Izuku told Aizawa about the dinner leftover part, conveniently leaving the part of their strained friendship out of his explanation.

Aizawa raised his eyebrows at the explanation. "It never looked like leftovers, at least to me. Bakugou has always been too good of a

cook to continuously cook too much dinner.”

Izuku laughed awkwardly at Aizawa’s reasoning. “Well, there’s no way Katsuki cooked it just for me, right? He must’ve just cooked too much, somehow.”

“I’m not trying to argue with you, Midoriya. You are the one who knows him best, anyway. But do you really think so little of yourself?”

Izuku was silent for a moment. Suddenly he got flashes of Katsuki saying, *“I think it's about time for you to think more highly of yourself, lest you won’t notice the most obvious thing.”* which felt like a lifetime ago now.

“Either way, you need to eat properly, problem child. I can count the times you eat a proper lunch this year with my fingers. Don’t waste your youth away by harming your body— *I know* it's rich coming from a hero who broke their back every day— but your older self will thank you if you start taking care of yourself more.”

Izuku was stunned at Aizawa’s advice. All this time, he never even noticed that he’d been neglecting *himself* too. Aizawa raised an eyebrow at him, clearly expecting some kind of a reaction from Izuku, so he just nodded dazedly.

"Will do, thank you, Aizawa-sense— *I mean*— -san!" Izuku blushed at his slip-up.

Aizawa let out an amused grunt before ruffling Izuku's head like he's still a UA student, and walked out of the office to eat his own lunch.

Izuku stared at his half-eaten onigiri for a while before sighing and wrapping it up for later. He knew Aizawa meant well, but his already low appetite for the cold onigiri was gone the moment he remembered Katsuki's flavorful lunches.

I cooked too much last night, so just eat it or throw it away; I don't care.

Always the same reason for *years* , how come Izuku never questioned Katsuki's motive even once?

Just stay put and don't aggravate your wound further, Izuku.

The way Katsuki cradled his younger self's body and called his name was so…intimate. The ugly feeling swirling in his stomach was back, and Izuku squashed it down before it could grow into something uglier.

You are the one who knows him best, anyway.

But did Izuku even know Katsuki anymore? He didn't even know what had become of *himself.*

— *Funded by Class A alumni with Young Bakugou at the heart of it!*

All Might's voice boomed in Izuku's head as he laid his eyes on his hero suit, which was sitting on the floor beside his desk.

For eight years, he had learned how to bury his dream.

But unbeknownst to him, for those eight years, Katsuki fought tooth and nail to bring his dream back.

And like the *Deku* he was, he turned tail and ran.

Make sure you do your damn best.

I'm the 'Deku' who always does his best!

It seemed that, after having the conversation with Ochako last night, a floodgate had been opened in his brain, and his thoughts were just filled to the brim with memories he'd tried so hard to repress since then.

Izuku pinched the bridge of his nose. He could tell the small beads of tears beginning to form at the corner of his eyes. He'd given up on continuing his work— it's almost finished anyway, he would have time to do it later, hopefully.

He didn't want anyone to walk in and see him crying on his seat in broad daylight, so he tried his best to wipe everything off before going to the restroom to wash his face.

It seemed that the universe was really hell-bent on rubbing even more salt to his wound today, because as soon as Izuku made a turn to an empty hallway—thinking he'd have a better chance of having a breakdown in the farthest restroom at the edge of the building— he ran into All Might, of all people.

"All Might!?" Izuku couldn't help but smile in All Might's presence. He'd missed his old mentor so much.

Everything started going downhill the moment he was no longer here, guiding him.

“Midoriya-shounen! Long time no see, my boy!” All Might’s brilliant smile matched his, and Izuku could only marvel in awe at the smile lines around All Might’s eyes. His eyes no longer looked gaunt, and he’s aging so gracefully now, with the current technology allowing his broken internal organs to be replaced so he could breathe easier.

“I thought… you’re staying in the US permanently now?” There’s a small, childish part of him that wanted to keep All Might close, but he knew deep down that he’s only one call away, had Izuku stopped being a coward and just called him regularly.

“I am! I’m here because Dave is finally retired, and we want to go to Okinawa for an overdue honeymoon. I decided to visit UA for a bit today to greet everyone before catching our flight there.” All Might explained, the grin never leaving his face. He looked a little bit flustered when he mentioned Professor David Shield, Melissa-san father, but—

Izuku’s brain screeched to a halt.

“A honeymoon??? You and D-Dave-san??” Izuku gasped. Since when?

“Huh, I thought I'd told you about us before?” All Might craned his head a bit in confusion. His earlier smile was replaced with a frown.

“N-no? I thought you were just reconnecting with an old friend?” Izuku quickly explained. He hated being the reason his mentor’s smile fell.

“Oh— that much is true, I suppose. But even after all this time, he was still the one who got me the most as a person. So since we’re not getting younger anymore, we thought it would be good for us to… enjoy the rest of our lives with no past burdening us.” All Might clarified with a nostalgic smile.

“O— Oh! I'm so happy for you, All Might!” Izuku said earnestly. His younger, chronically online fanboy self would be losing his mind right now.

“And me for you, Midoriya-shounen! How are you and Bakugou-shounen doing these days?” All Might asked, curiosity lighting up his voice.

“I- huh? Katsuki? But we— we’re not…” Izuku was taken aback by the question. It seemed like, no matter how hard he tried to run away again, Katsuki seemed to be the hot topic of the day.

“Am I mistaken? Did you not tell me about your relationship about one and a half years ago?”

“Oh no, no, no… That was… me and Ochako! But we actually just, uh— We just broke up yesterday, actually…” Screw past Izuku for being intentionally vague back when he first told All Might about his newly budding relationship. But back then, telling All Might straight that Ochako was his girlfriend left a sour taste in his mouth.

In hindsight, it’s very obvious why Izuku’s feeling that way. While he didn’t regret becoming closer to Ochako again, deep down he constantly felt guilty for the real reason he just randomly decided to give their friendship another go again, and for thinking they could have something more when their relationship was never founded out of romantic attraction in the first place.

“Young Uraraka??? Forgive my assumptions, but I assumed…” All Might was stupefied by the mention of a different name.

“Why do you assume I was talking about Kacc-Katsuki?”

“Well, isn't it obvious, my boy? Or maybe it was more obvious from my end, because I have watched Bakugou-shounen pouring his everything into the last 8 years just to get you back on the field with him. How he made sure everything fits like a glove for you, like you've never lost One for All in the first place. I've never seen such dedication from a person, and what could it be for, if not love?” All Might’s smile was soft and nostalgic, like he was reminiscing about Katsuki in those eight years Izuku didn’t have the privilege to witness.

Love.

Just one word, and the world as Izuku knew it collapsed around him.

There’s no more room for doubt now. All this time, Kat — Kacchan was…

Oh, Izuku wanted to throw up.

“Are you okay, Midoriya-shounen?” All Might looked at Izuku concernedly, afraid that he was saying too much.

“Yeah — I’m. Yeah. Thank you, All Might.”

“Anytime, my boy. Let's catch up after my vacation; I can't wait to hear more about you and the suit!”

“Mmhmm!!” Izuku nodded with a smile that didn’t quite reach his eyes.

They parted ways with a wave, with All Might going in the direction of the teacher’s office to greet the other teachers. The moment All Might was out of sight, Izuku bolted to the nearest restroom and was so thankful to find it almost empty.

He opened the faucet and immediately splashed his face a few times with running water, ignoring the confused look of several general education students who just witnessed the famous War Hero turned Hero Course Teacher Deku vigorously scrubbing his face out like a madman. They quietly scurried out of the restroom, and soon, Izuku was truly alone.

Izuku looked up and scanned his reflection in the mirror. His eyes were rimmed red, and there were visible black circles underneath them. His skin looked dull, and his hair was an unruly mess. Seriously, what did Kacchan even see in him?

Kacchan, who was always amazing. Kacchan, who never gave up on his dream, on *Izuku's dream* . Kacchan, who always knew Izuku so well, even when Izuku didn’t understand himself anymore.

Kacchan, who came back to life and immediately became Izuku’s hero when he thought all hope was lost. Kacchan, who Izuku thought was forever out of reach…had been trying to meet him in the middle all this time.

Izuku was special to Kacchan; that’s the undeniable truth.

But what about Izuku?

I thought—with everything that happened… We're on the way to becoming closer to each other.

No, Izuku-kun, I'm asking—are you in love with Bakugou-kun?

Do you like… the present I left you? All for One in Shigaraki's body taunted him the moment he arrived on the battlefield, but his mind was only full of Kacchan.

Kacchan, who was lying on the ground motionless. Dead.

Izuku paled, trying desperately to block that damning memory from his head. Never again. He didn't want to see that ever again. Izuku could not go through that ever again — *except he would, because he's a coward who ran away when he should be standing at Kacchan's side—*

All this time, you've been putting Bakugou-kun and your ideal heroism on the same pedestal, and because you felt undeserving of one—

Even after all this time, he was still the one who got me the most.

Who am I kidding? It's always going to be Kacchan, isn't it? Saying that it's natural they drifted apart as they grew up was just an excuse. The line between wanting to be a hero and wanting to be by Kacchan's side had been blurred since a long time ago; or maybe it had never existed in the first place.

Even the word 'love' couldn't fully encompass the whole spectrum of Izuku's feelings for Kacchan. He's the one constant in his life, the one he couldn't imagine existing without, the sun to Izuku's moon, and his — *his soulmate.*

Izuku got into all of this mess because he's running away from half of his soul, because he couldn't withstand his own weakness. Even though Kacchan had always tried to meet Izuku head-on, and only stopped because Izuku —*the biggest idiot on earth*— acted like he no longer wanted Kacchan in his life.

Oh god , Izuku's heart broke when he realized how awful Kacchan must have felt on the night Izuku rejected his offer to join his agency. And Izuku had the gall to call Kacchan shortly after that day to tell him that he and Ochako got together.

Izuku wholeheartedly hoped it wasn't too late for him to tell Kacchan that he'd always been special to him, too.

Something lit inside his chest, a feeling that Izuku never allowed himself to experience for years; it almost felt foreign now. He wanted to meet Kacchan, to apologize, to beg, to fight for the right to be by his side again.

No amount of self-reflection in a single day could erase almost a decade's worth of guilt and self-loathing, but *damn, Izuku wanted to try, for Kacchan.*

Izuku vowed to himself to never take Kacchan for granted again, for the rest of his life.

Tears flowed freely across his cheeks as he tried hard to compose himself. His hands were shaky as he tried to wash his face again. Break time is ending soon, and Izuku needed to remain presentable until the end of the day.

Tonight, Izuku vowed. *Tonight we'll talk, and I'll tell him everything. I'll stop running away.*

✦✧

The moment the final bell rang, Izuku sprung from his seat and rushed to collect all of his stuff from the desk. “Don’t forget to do all of your homework! See you tomorrow, everyone!” He shouted as he ran for the door. He’s very early for their scheduled dinner, but Izuku could care less as he runs in the direction of the diner.

Halfway through his sprint, Izuku realized that even though he’s finished with his work, Kacchan might not be finished with his patrol yet. Chastising himself for being overly eager, Izuku slowed down to a jog. He took a deep breath, trying to calm his full-body jitters before taking in his surroundings.

He’s currently in an outdoor shopping area, and there’s some people walking around leisurely in the open pedestrian space. From the corner of his vision, he saw some crowd flocking around a big screen on the side of the building. The screen was televising a… fight?

“Hey, isn’t that not too far from here?” One of the people muttered anxiously the moment Izuku got closer to the crowd.

“Shouldn’t we, you know, run?”

“Nah, Dynamight’s fighting! The fight will be over soon, for sure!”

Izuku whipped his gaze to the screen so fast at the mention of Kacchan’s name. True to the pedestrian, Kacchan was fighting *alone*

against a villain. At first, Izuku echoed the sentiment; Kacchan would definitely win easily. But then, he saw some telltale sluggishness from Kacchan's movement. He's not in his best shape; *why?*

Suddenly, a loud explosion was heard from outside the screen, definitely too close to where Izuku was standing for comfort. The crowds dispersed, screaming and running to safety, but Izuku's eyes stayed glued to the screen. Kacchan was on the defensive. Was he not able to go all out because there were pedestrians nearby? Or was it because of something else?

The villain managed to catch Kacchan off guard and landed a mean attack on his side, sending Kacchan careening into a building. Before his mind could comprehend the situation, his body had already moved on its own. Izuku ran to the source of the explosion.

"Kacchan!"

✦✧

Chapter End Notes

Okay so, I lowkey cried writing the last part.

Also I've been trying to make sense of why All Might wasn't in 431, and the best idea I can come up with is 'well maybe he

decided to live his best retirement life with his bf in the US!!' So yeah, sorry for the sudden old man yaoi inclusion lmao

Next chapter will finally be the last, and chapter 7 will be short epilogues for current timeline and past timeline BKDK!
I miss baby Izuku a lot so I'm excited to write about him again hehe.

I also just published a short BKDK actor AU one shot, please give it a read if it's your cup of tea!

Kudos and comments are very very appreciated! See you on the next chapter~

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

> "It's been lonely without you, Kacchan. I'm so sorry that I've been so caught up in my grief that I didn't realize I hurt you, too. I want to get better— I need to strive to be better. Once I do, would you please— Do you want— Can we please save and win together again?"
>
> ✦✧
>
> Our Twin Star finally had a heart-to-heart.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku rushed in to join the fight with his suit. He immediately activated Blackwhip and Float to get to Katsuki as fast as possible. Just as he was about to blast through the street, however, Blackwhip sputtered, and Izuku almost lost his balance.

Low battery detected. Activating emergency power mode. The suit's AI voice piped up, and Izuku's eyes widened in horror.

Did he forget to charge the suit yesterday?

Oh no. No, no, no, Izuku half-ran, half-swinging lightly with Blackwhip to conserve energy. He usually checked the suit's

condition right before bed, but yesterday had been so draining for him, it didn't even cross his mind to *check.*

Izuku observed Katsuki's fight from where he was in panic. Katsuki's gotten up again, but it's clear whatever the villain did made Katsuki unable to go all out against them. Izuku could only watch as Katsuki dodged the villain's barrage of attacks. *He's too far; he wouldn't make it in time —*

So that's it, Hero?

Tenko's taunting voice woke Izuku up like a splash of cold water. His whole body shook anxiously, but Izuku clenched his fist and forced his body to relax. He took a deep breath and tried to clear his mind.

Now isn't the time to give up! Izuku gritted his teeth and commanded the suit to return back into a suitcase.

"Scan the area for civilians! Call for backup and search for a safe place to go rest mode and focus all the remaining power on Blackwhip!" One of the gloves detached from the rest of the suit and attached itself into Izuku's palms. *Barely enough power for one glove, huh?* Izuku willed himself to focus.The small screen on his glove beeped and he gasped.

There's one civilian trapped dangerously near to where Katsuki was fighting.

Izuku immediately rushed in the civilian's direction. Saving lives came first. He had to make do with what he's got, he thought as he swung from building to building with Blackwhip, taking advantage of the momentum to gain distance while conserving energy.

The moment he got near the battleground, he could finally make out what the villain was saying.

"—Fancy, isn't it? I must thank you and *Deku* for it, honestly." The villain cackled while extending sharp, extending tendrils from his—mechanical sleeves almost identical to Izuku's… suit?

What is happening? Izuku gasped silently. For a moment he thought the villain had figured out where he was, but they didn't seem to notice him yet, so Izuku decided to rescue the civilian swiftly so Katsuki could fight more freely. Izuku turned his gaze to a pile of rubble two floors below where Katsuki was standing.

"All that cutting-edge technology…wasted on a *teacher* from a rich, spoiled brat's school." The villain's words were filled with vitriol. "Couldn't blame *us* for taking a little inspiration, honestly. How do you like it, Dynamy?"

"It's *Great Explosion Murder God Dynamight* to your shitty ass, and the suit's fucking classified!"

"Aww, of course there's a way for us to access classified information. Especially when our little heroes were so delusional with the idea of peace; *all of you* chose to turn a blind eye to the shadows lurking in the *deep.* "

Izuku paled at the villain's ramble. *Someone got the data for his suit and tried to replicate it?* Panic began to seep into every crevice of Izuku's body, and he could feel the beginning of a panic attack in the way his throat started to close up, making him silently gasp for air.

Everything was his fault, a small voice at the back of his consciousness said. *It's because he lost One for All…*

Meeting his younger self really made all of his ugly insecurities rise up to the surface again, after years of trying to drown them away.

When he was in the middle of wallowing in self-pity, Izuku accidentally locked eyes with the terrified civilian trapped beneath the rubble. She was a middle-aged woman, and her arm was stretched out in Izuku's direction, silently asking for help, though most of her body was trapped in the rubble. Izuku could see that her body wasn't squashed, thankfully.

Izuku steeled himself to focus. He promised to control his heart one last time to get through this; after that, he promised to never lock it away again.

Once Izuku was close enough, he smiled reassuringly at the civilian. "Hello Ma'am, are you hurt anywhere? Let me get you out of the rubble into a safe place, okay?"

The woman sobbed, seemingly recognizing Izuku. "Oh, thank goodness… Hero Deku is here, thank goodness…"

Izuku began to lift the rubble one by one, taking note of the structure and only removing the safe ones until the civilian could shimmy out of the crevice. One of the things Izuku was very grateful for was that for years, even after the embers had snuffed out, Katsuki never stopped dragging his quirkless self to the gym to stay fit and to spar, so he maintained all of his muscles and was able to lift everything without relying on his suit.

The middle-aged woman sighed in relief the moment she was back on her feet, and Izuku let out a small smile at her. Then suddenly, the entire collapsing building shook by the force of Katsuki's explosion, and the woman yelped before clutching Izuku's middle for dear life.

"Hey! It's okay, it's okay! Let's get you somewhere safe, okay?" Izuku gently lifted the woman in a bridal carry so he could navigate

through the rubble to the ground floor more easily. From behind him, the villain continued to taunt Katsuki.

"C'mon, is this all you got, Dynamy? Heroes these days are so *weak!* Nothing more than a pretty face on a billboard. Did winning a war inflate your ego that much?" The villain continued to send those sharp nail-like things to chase after Katsuki, who blasted them away while dodging midair.

"We are the harbingers of doom!" The villain spread his hands cartoonishly while shouting at the top of their lungs. "This so-called peaceful era is suffocating. We're here to remind you that the brighter the lights, the darker the shado— *URK!"*

"Shut the fuck up, you fucking B-lister!" Katsuki had enough of the cringy monologue and blasted the villain across his face until their mask burned to crisps. When the mask fell away, however, Katsuki's frown deepened at what he saw.

The villain's face was marred full of scars of varying severity. One of his eyes was milky white. The side of his head was scarred from burns, and one of his ears was missing. He looked like he'd gone through every torture known to man until his face no longer held the shape. In comparison, Katsuki's earlier explosion straight to the face did nothing but cause a light burn.

The villain must have perceived Katsuki's bewildered look as disgust and began cackling madly. "How do you like my face, hero?" He grinned, and the deep lacerations around his mouth pulled taut.

"My quirk allows me to not feel pain," the villain sneered. "These," he gestured to his face and *to his whole body* that's similarly also covered in scars. "Was the result of years of human curiosity. That's right. They don't parade around as a villain; they're just helpless civilians heroes save everyday on their job, yet they're able to inflict all of these just because I am unable to feel it."

Katsuki's eyes widened in realization.

The villain continued to ramble. "Before long, my face looked like this, and even *heroes* steer clear of me. They think little ol' ugly me is a fucking liar." The villain licked the blood that dripped down near his mouth. "They think my *quirk* is not 'villainous' enough to join Uravity's sunshine and rainbows counseling, but I'm a *villain* for looking like this. So I thought, *so be it, then* . I'll be the villain you made me to be! I will destroy your fake peace and return it to the Demon Lord's era, where humanity was exposed to its villainous root, without the fake 'we're supposed to help each other' bullshit!"

The villain dove in Katsuki's direction using the thrusters on his legs. Katsuki tried to blast him away, but since the villain couldn't feel pain, he kept getting closer, taking Katsuki's attacks head-on. Katsuki ended up having to dodge his sharp, elongated metal nails, create some distance so he wouldn't end up accidentally fatally injuring the

villain, and keep the destruction to the minimum all at the same time.

Izuku barely got the civilian out of the danger zone and told her to run to safety before he turned back just in time just to see Katsuki getting surrounded by those sharp nail-like tentacles that just kept on multiplying.

Izuku's breath caught in his throat the moment he saw Katsuki's footing slip from where he stood 3 stories high due to the nonstop jabs and cuts sent his way, taking a toll on his focus.

Suddenly, Izuku was sixteen again at Jaku. Then, he's at his apartment looking at his younger self, who had just witnessed his biggest nightmare, calling for his Kacchan.

Before Izuku knew it, he was already zipping through the sky with the last splutter of Blackwhip. His thoughts were filled with *never again!* As he snatched Katsuki out of harm's way while using the momentum to hit the villain square on the chest with his shoot style until he fell to the ground. All raw power, no quirk needed.

Katsuki, cradled awkwardly in Izuku's arm, thought he was dreaming as he looked up. For a split second, Izuku's face overlapped with his younger self. So full of life and determination, like the light in his eyes was finally reignited once more.

He looked every bit like the Hero Katsuki missed so much.

Katsuki snapped back into reality the moment he noticed they were free-falling to the ground, and he immediately activated his explosion to control their fall. Izuku put him down once they reached the ground and ran to the villain's side, kicking the crudely made support sleeves off the villain, who groaned half unconsciously.

Katsuki got the memo and immediately blasted the support items on the villain's hands and legs to smithereens, thus incapacitating the villain. He then snapped a quirk-canceling cuff on his hands and legs for good measure, but the villain is already out cold by the sheer force of Izuku's kick.

It seemed that even though he's immune to pain, he could still feel the side-effects from the inflicted pain. Katsuki made a mental note to brief the officer in charge of his case to make sure he got into a proper rehabilitation center instead of just throwing him into a prison cell to rot.

Izuku's hands were shaking like crazy from adrenaline and all the repressed emotion he felt all at once as he saw the villain lying on the ground unconscious. He then snapped his head up to look at Katsuki, who's standing there, *unharmed* save for a few shallow cuts, and suddenly Izuku couldn't stop the tears from flowing.

“You saved my ass, Deku.” Kacchan broke the silence reverently the moment their eyes met. “Don’t even need the suit, huh? Fucking show off.”

Izuku sobbed. The euphoria was threatening to explode his chest out into the atmosphere, and the voice of doubt was still there.

But Kacchan’s alive. Izuku saved him just in time.

Izuku didn't fail.

He was feeling way too much in that moment while looking at Kacchan, who was smiling proudly at him. *He’s beautiful,* Izuku’s mind supplied. Like a moth drawn to flame, his body moved on its own to catch Kacchan's lips in a kiss.

✦✧

Katsuki felt the pressure on his lips before he could process it.

What the fuck.

His eyes were wide open, and he could see the details of Izuku's lashes. Izuku’s eyes were closed, and there were a few drops of tears that clung to his lashes. His lips were dry and chapped, but the way they moved against Katsuki’s was gentle.

Did I die in battle and go to heaven somewhat? Was Katsuki’s first thought while he unconsciously let out a relieved sigh and kissed Izuku back just as passionately. But the sting from multiple cuts on his body told him that he's still pretty much alive, and Izuku was still kissing him frantically with trembling lips.

Katsuki weakly pushed him away, mumbling, “What the fuck, Deku!?” Tragically, a small part of him couldn’t help but mourn the loss of Izuku’s lips against his. Fuck, he would never get a chance like this again.

Izuku opened his eyes, and tears spilled freely from his emerald orbs. Katsuki missed them so much. “Kacchan, you’re alive.” He said it like a prayer, making Katsuki shiver.

“Of course I'm alive, shit nerd, what does that have to do with anything?” Izuku blushed so red down to his neck, seemingly just realizing what he’d done. Before he could explain, however, the police had arrived.

Both of them immediately went into professional mode to assist the police until the villain was safely detained. And after, they continued to give their statement at the ambulance while they got their injuries looked at. Katsuki got a lot of minor cuts, but thankfully, nothing life-threatening. After bidding goodbyes with the officers, Katsuki glared at Izuku, as if saying, *you still owe me an explanation.*

Izuku opened his mouth to stutter his explanation, but his stomach answered for him. It let out a rumble so loud, the nearest police officer, who was already walking away from them, whipped his head back at the sound, and Izuku wanted the ground to swallow him alive. That's what he got from skipping lunch, he supposed.

Izuku bowed to the officer, muttering apologies while being reassured, "No, it's okay, I hope you'll have a great dinner after!" Said the officer, who rapidly bowed to match Izuku's pace.

Katsuki stared at Izuku long after the officer had left in bewilderment before laughing his ass off at Izuku's expense.

"Some things never change, huh? Let's get that dinner first, 'Zuku."

✦✧

The moment they finally sat down at their usual table at Aoi-san's restaurant, both of them sighed in relief. It was a moderately busy night, but thankfully the other customers who saw the two disheveled, grimy heroes decided to let them be and did not approach them.

Izuku safely deposited his suitcase below the table, just as Aoi-san came to their table to happily greet them. "I was sitting at the edge of my seat the entire fight! You young'uns really reminded me of All Might, saving the day like it was just a walk in the park! The last kick was especially *cool,* Izuku!" He was looking at them like a proud father, and both Katsuki and Izuku grinned bashfully at him.

"The whole kitchen's so happy to see you coming here together again, too! Should've seen it coming when Katsuki suddenly came here yesterday with your cousin— never mind that, what do you boys want to order today?"

"Cousin?" Izuku whispered and whipped his head in Katsuki's direction. Katsuki just shook his head slightly and gestured for Izuku to ask later. *Ah,* Izuku realized. Katsuki must have brought Izuku's younger self to try Aoi-san's food yesterday.

Izuku hummed while scanning the menu absent-mindedly. The post-battle adrenaline had slowly faded away, but Izuku still felt the courage and euphoria coursing through his whole body down to his fingertips. With a smile, he ordered the same dish he's one hundred percent sure his younger self ordered yesterday. "I'd get the special Mighty Katsudon, please!"

"Oh! It's been a while since you ordered that, hasn't it? I'll make sure to make it extra special! Bwa-ha-ha!"

Katsuki raised his eyebrow at Izuku, and Izuku laughed awkwardly. "Ah—yeah… All the food on the menu looks great, so I wanted to try them all!"

"And now that you've tried them all, what's the verdict?" Aoi-san grinned at Izuku. The old chef's grin was so contagious Izuku couldn't help but to grin back. Aoi-san reminded him of All Might, of *home.* It's only fitting that he was a die-hard All Might fan too, like Izuku.

"Mmhmm yeah— turns out Katsudon is still my favorite!" Izuku answered, smiling at Katsuki as he said so.

To no one's surprise, Katsuki ordered the Hellfire Curry Rice with Plus Ultra Spicy Karaage on the side.

While waiting for their order to finish cooking, Izuku asked Katsuki about his younger self. "You brought him here?"

Katsuki snickered. "Yeah. Did you know he actually lost his goddamn mind after seeing his precious All Might figure collections here

instead of sitting prettily inside a tempered glass cabinet in your apartment?”

Izuku went red. “W-well, at least my collections are in good hands here! You know Aoi-san is a big fan of All Might just like us, right? It would just collect dust if I kept it at my place, anyway, given how busy I am…” Izuku pouted a bit.

“Yeah, right, so busy to even eat a proper lunch, by the sound of it.” Katsuki rolled his eyes at Izuku, and Izuku felt heat rising to his cheeks.

“I ate an onigiri for lunch! Besides, today is…different. I’m super behind on my schedule and have a lot of thoughts I need to sort through, so… I barely have time for anything else,” Izuku admitted sullenly.

Katsuki sighed before flicking him in the forehead. “You idiot. Taking care of yourself should be a priority. What would your precious students think if their Sensei keeled over mid-lesson because he’s ‘too busy to eat’?”

Izuku let out an embarrassed giggle before the earlier conversation with Aizawa-san popped up in his mind.

“Come to think of it, I don’t think I ever thanked you enough for always bringing me lunch for years, Katsuki,” Izuku’s pulse quickened in anticipation of Katsuki’s response. The thing about them was that they *never* talked about things like this. Given what Izuku finally realized now, he knew he was the one who had to start pushing for it, since Katsuki seemed content to just never acknowledge anything.

“T’was nothing. I just cooked too much, that’s all.”

Izuku hummed. Of course Katsuki would deny it until the end of time.

“Then, did you learn how to cook the correct portions around a year ago?”

Katsuki stared at Izuku incredulously before looking away in defeat. “Sure, I guess. It’s not that big of a deal. I’m sure Round Face wouldn’t like it if I keep sending you lunches too—” Katsuki only mumbled the last part, but Izuku heard him just the same.

“Hmm? What did Ochako have to do with it?”

“Are you fucking for real, shitty nerd?”

“Huh? I don’t under—” Izuku leaned over to Katsuki’s space to search for an explanation, but his sentence was cut short.

“Boys! Your food’s here!!” Aoi-san’s booming voice shook both boys to the core, and Izuku almost lurched forward and made a mess of himself and his freshly made bowl of Katsudon if not for Katsuki’s steady hand gripping into his shoulder to stop him from falling headfirst to the table.

“They all look so good! Thank you so much, Aoi-san!” Izuku pretended his little slip-up never happened and started singing praises for the older man’s cooking. Katsuki just watched him babble with an indescribable look in his eyes.

“Had to go Plus-Ultra for my favorite customers!” Aoi-san beamed at the praise. “Come to think of it, how’s your brown-haired girl, Izuku? She couldn’t come today?”

“Ah—Um. Well…” Izuku never thought the question would arrive this fast. He hadn’t even told anyone but All Might about this, and speaking about it again and again made it feel like it was *real.* Katsuki was trying to feign disinterest by taking the first bite of his curry rice.

“We—we just broke up, actually.”

Katsuki immediately choked on his ultra-spicy curry the same time Aoi-san let out a sympathetic noise.

Izuku shouted in worry as Katsuki coughed and wheezed. “Kac—Katsuki!”

“I’ll get your drink right away!” Aoi-san turned his heel to the serving station to grab some tea and immediately poured a glass for Katsuki, who downed it like a man stranded in a desert.

“I never would’ve thought my curry could do some serious damage to Dynamight of all people…” Aoi-san guffawed light-heartedly. “And here I was planning to make a spicier menu with your name on it!”

“You’d better still do it—old man,” Katsuki coughed out threateningly. “This is nothing; I just inhaled at the wrong time.”

“If you say so, my boy!” Aoi-san turned to Izuku. “It’s her loss; I know you’ll find someone better, so chin up, Izuku!” He patted Izuku on the back a few times before going back to the kitchen to prepare more orders.

Izuku awkwardly cleared his throat. That was just a normal reaction after hearing someone you knew broke up with their girlfriend, but why did Izuku feel so uneasy? Maybe he just didn’t like to be pitied? or maybe—

Izuku realized that he just didn't *feel* any losses after the break up. Ochako and he were still friends, arguably with an even closer friendship than before. And their relationship wasn't a passionate one, anyway. The stakes were so *low* , Izuku didn't feel the absence of it once it was over. *Gosh, I'm the worst.* Izuku mentally berated himself for thinking this way because that's just not fair for Ochako. After everything that had transpired, she's still a dear friend, after all. Shouldn't Izuku feel at least a little bit sa—

"Oi, earth to nerd."

Katsuki's irritated voice snapped Izuku out of his rumination. He looked up and met Kacchan's frowning eyes. "Yes, Kacc—Katsuki?"

Katsuki blinked at Izuku's slip-up and clicked his tongue. "You're doing it again."

"D-doing what?"

"You called me Kacchan during battle, but now you're back to trying to call me Katsuki. Explain," he ordered.

"I-I mean, isn't it childish? I thought you hated it?"

If a glare was enough to obliterate a person, Izuku would be nothing but dust right now. Katsuki was looking at Izuku like he offended his whole extended family and All Might at the same time. “Nah, never call me Katsuki again; it sounds weird coming from you.” He demanded petulantly. Was he… pouting?

“So…Kacchan?”

“Don't make me repeat myself, nerd.” Kat—Kacchan shoved a big mouthful of spicy curry and rice into his mouth and began chomping on it.

“Okay, Kacchan!” Izuku couldn't help but blush a little at the childish nickname, but calling Kacchan ‘Kacchan’ instead of ‘Katsuki’ felt… good. Better. Like the invisible rift between them slowly mending itself.

Kacchan’s lips pulled upwards into a wobbly smile for a second before he covered it with his hand, still trying hard to maintain his tough guy persona. Izuku caught it anyway, and all his prior reservations were immediately replaced with fondness. He would do anything to be the reason for Kacchan's smile for the rest of his life, he realized.

Then, Izuku remembered the kiss.

Went beet red. He went ahead of himself…What if he assumed wrong? Kacchan didn't seem to be happy when he kissed him, too. What if he ruined things between them before it had any chance to start?

"Oi nerd, what are you thinking so loudly about?" Kacchan nursed his tea while calling Izuku out. Izuku was so lost spiraling inside his own head that he almost missed it.

"Ah! No, I want to say I'm sorry for k-k-kis—" Izuku felt heat rising up to his whole face. He couldn't say it with a straight face!

"Pfft, what kind of a grown man got so flustered by the word 'kiss'?"

"K-kacchan!!"

"Why did you do it, Izuku?" Kacchan looked at him dead in the eye, his expression unreadable. Maybe Izuku read him wrong, but there's some hopefulness in the way Kacchan's eyes focused on him.

"I—um. Not here, please."

Kacchan raised an eyebrow.

"Can we talk privately?" Izuku glanced at the bustling tables around them. It's hard to preserve privacy in a public restaurant at peak hours, even though their table was strategically placed at the back.

Katsuki pondered for a minute before answering. "Let's go to my apartment after this."

Izuku's heart skipped a beat at the way Kacchan said it. *Just to talk, Izuku, just to talk.* He chastised himself before letting his imagination run wild. He suddenly remembered Ochako's suggestive look this morning and was mortified. She'd tease him to the end of time if something *more* ended up happening; he's sure of it.

"Okay, Kacchan," he answered obediently. Well, it was better than having a meltdown in a public space, he guessed.

"Now, finish your food before the Katsudon gets all soggy and gross."

"R-right!"

✦✧

"Come to think of it, why didn't you use the suit earlier?" Kacchan asked as they finished their dinner.

"Uh," Izuku replied dumbly. *Ah… I'm done for.* "It…ran out of battery?"

"Izuku, I put in like, five different reminders to charge the suit."

"Yeah, I know… I may or may not have ignored them all? I think? B-because I was super busy for the whole week! And yesterday happened, and—" He grimaced at himself for making such lame excuses. *I hope my mom knows I love her.*

Izuku fully expected Kacchan to kill him for being so careless with the suit. What he didn't expect was for Kacchan to look at him dead in the eye with the most exasperated look known to man.

"You're an idiot." Kacchan stated simply. (*Why do you think I put FIVE reminders in the suit, you shitty nerd?)*

Izuku leaned back against his chair, closed his eyes, and sighed. “Tell me about it…”

✦✧

After dinner, they went to Kacchan's apartment to talk.

“So,” Kacchan broke the silence the moment he closed the door behind him. “You broke up with Cheeks?”

Izuku nodded while touching the back of his neck awkwardly. “Yeah, it was— it was a mutual decision. We’re still friends, though.” He mirrored Kacchan’s movement to take off his shoes and placed them side by side at the *genkan.*

“Why so sudden?” Kacchan said before walking towards the living area.

“Ah…” Izuku hesitated a bit before explaining.”After you and the younger me left, we…had a conversation. I think the moment I saw how different I was acting back then… Even though Ochako and I kept smiling at each other after, we can both sense that our relationship is already broken beyond repair.” He stood awkwardly at

the entrance of Kacchan's apartment before deciding to follow him inside.

"No shit, I saw the coffee table." Kacchan made a light quip while gesturing for Izuku to take a seat on the sofa, taking note of how stiff he was when explaining. He turned on the TV to act as background noise so the atmosphere of the room wasn't as tense, but both of them only had eyes for each other.

Izuku chuckled lightly before hesitantly taking a seat beside Kacchan on the sofa. "That too. But it felt like our relationship was built on us trying to put band-aids to cover up our problems… and we just realized that the band-aids no longer worked." Izuku smiled sadly. "So we talked, and decided that going our separate ways is the best decision for both of our sakes."

Kacchan was silent for a while. "And?" He prompted Izuku to continue his explanation with a raise of his eyebrow.

"I—Uh… I had an epiphany. Sort of?" Izuku looked down at his lap, deciding looking at his fingers was more interesting than looking at Kacchan's demanding gaze.

"I think I did like her a lot, but it's different than how I love you," Izuku blurted before he could think, and covered his mouth with his hands and snapped his eyes upwards the moment he realized what he'd just said out loud.

Kacchan’s face was red; his eyes and jaw were wide open in shock. “Dont fuck with me, Izuku,” he said angrily.

“No— I’m— this isn’t how I imagined this is going to go— B-but I’m not lying to you! I promise!” Izuku moved his hands up and down animatedly in an attempt to explain himself. He was expecting Kacchan to explode him, but what he saw made him stop in his tracks.

Kacchan snarled and looked every bit like the fiery boy Izuku knew his whole life, but he could also see Kacchan’s lips trembling and his eyes were bloodshot and a little too glassy. Izuku almost lost it from the guilt. *I really am the worst.*

“I—um, Kacchan…I!” Words got caught in Izuku's throat. What could he say in this situation? *I just realized that you’re in love with me. I’m sorry I didn’t realize sooner. I’m sorry I hurt you, but I want to be selfish and try to be with you now anyway?*

Yeah, right.

This is way too soon. Izuku should’ve taken 7 business days to process everything and recover. He took a deep breath and slowly released it in an attempt to calm his heart.

Kacchan stayed silent. But Izuku could see in his eyes that he was waiting for Izuku to say something.

"I miss you, Kacchan." Izuku admitted. "Ever since I received the suit… I've been running away. From you. From hero work. It took Ochako spelling it out for me that my view of heroism is tightly woven with how I feel for you for me to stop running. But still, I think all this time I felt— unsteady." Izuku struggled to find the right words under Kacchan's hurtful gaze, but in a spurt of courage, Izuku's hand reached forward to touch Kacchan's own hands in a featherlight touch, asking for permission.

"The suit was never made to weigh you down, Izuku." Kacchan looked heartbroken. But he intertwined his fingers with Izuku's all the same, and Izuku felt hope blooming in his chest. He belatedly realized that they had never actually held hands outside of battle necessity before, but they just slotted together so effortlessly like they'd been holding each other's hands their whole life; it's unbelievable.

"I know, Kacchan." Izuku rubbed his thumb up and down Kacchan's palms reassuringly. "I know you meant well. It's just that I— it's a lot." He confessed. "I thought I had convinced myself enough that I was happy, living the way I was, but—" Izuku shifted his body so he could lean against the couch on his side more comfortably and pulled Kacchan to do the same.

"Something always felt a little off." Izuku continued once Kacchan had settled down too."It's like walking on a tightrope with no end in

sight. I thought if I have a stable relationship, maybe I can feel secure enough, that I can feel happy enough." And once the stone started rolling, Izuku found himself unable to stop talking.

"I feel like… All these years, I've been going through the motion of a predetermined checklist of what constitutes a 'happy, successful life.' Everyone's expecting something from me, whether as a hero or as a person, so since I couldn't give anything back to them as a hero, I tried my best to appear like I had my life together. Talking with Ochako yesterday made me realize that I've been taking advantage of her companionship to keep up appearances. I'm such a terrible person; even if she decided it was mutual, I was the one who started it." Izuku closed his eyes in shame, but Kacchan's steady grip on his hands gave him the courage to continue:

"When I tried the suit for the first time, Kacchan… It's so perfect that it felt like I've never lost OFA in the first place. That freaked me out so bad. It felt like everything just clicked into place, everything that I've been missing all these years." Izuku could feel the tell-tale sting of fresh tears at the edge of his eyes, but he blinked it away. He should at least try to finish his explanation with clarity before he lost himself in sobs and hiccups.

"I couldn't believe I got to fly through the air and be a hero *with you* again. But— with those euphoric moments, the guilt that came with it was just too much. **"** Izuku's lips trembled at the admission.

Kacchan hummed, eyes sad but understanding. He patiently waited for Izuku to momentarily compose himself without interrupting.

“It felt like I had to step inside a pair of shoes that were already way too big for me. Do you know how that feels, having all those expectations as Deku the war hero every time someone saw me? Some hero I was; I can’t even save Tenko, can’t even continue to do my damn best despite that being his last words to me. I’m barely 26 and everyone was expecting me to do more. I can’t fulfill those expectations anymore, Kacchan. Not when I’ve been grounded for so long. Not when I’m quirkless, I know I can’t.” Izuku began to heave at the end, and Kacchan let go of his hand to cup his cheeks in between his warm, soft palms.

“Izuku, you are a hero, with or without quirk. I thought I made it clear for you already!” Kacchan yelled desperately. “Was everything I did meaningless, in the end? No matter how hard I tried, the damage I’ve done to you was already taking root in your heart. Tell me, Izuku, what should I do to make you believe that you’re *good* ? All my good parts I owe them to you, but it seems that all of your bad parts were my fault.” Despite being the one who was hurting the most, Kacchan’s thumbs were still wiping the tears that escaped Izuku’s eyes oh-so-gently.

“No, Kacchan, I already said that I forgave you a long time ago!”

“That meant jack shit if you still believe everything middle school me said to you! You are not an extra— I told the younger you the same yesterday. You’re a hero at heart, a reckless, self-sacrificing piece of shit with a bleeding heart the size of an ocean. And it took me a long time to accept that you’re always going to be a better hero than I’ll ever be, but I also came to realize that you’re going to bleed

yourself to death if you keep this going!" Kacchan's voice cracked at the sudden increase in volume, and he took a deep breath to compose himself before he let anger overtake him. Now that the opportunity to properly talk with Izuku was finally here, he couldn't fuck this up by being his ol' short-tempered self. Kacchan took one, two, deep breaths before continuing with a significantly gentler tone.

"You can't keep pretending you're okay because that's what people expected of you, Izuku. You're only human. You have to let yourself grieve and heal. You don't even have to use the suit. Hell, just throw it away if you truly don't want to be a hero anymore. I just— I just want you to be *okay."* Kacchan lowered his hands away from Izuku's cheeks, but Izuku quickly chased his hands and held them tight.

"Kacchan…" Izuku sniffled while clutching Katsuki's hands for dear life. Katsuki held on to Izuku's hands just as hard, thumb rubbing over the scars like a prayer. All these years, the scars were a representation of Izuku's bleeding heart for everyone. Much like Katsuki's scars, which were entirely made in Izuku's name.

"I…everyone was celebrating." Izuku's mind went back to the immediate end of the war, to the conversation with Spinner, and to that night on the cliff with Ochako.

"So you felt like you couldn't be open with your grief? Where have I heard that one before, I wonder? You two are truly two peas in a pod." Kacchan rolled his eyes exasperatedly at Izuku, whose smile didn't reach his tired eyes.

“The truth was, we all pushed you to blow the last hit, Izuku. So if anything—”

“No, but… No one else saw what I had seen, Kacchan. The world didn’t see Tenko; they didn’t see him helping me deal the last blow to All for One. At the end of the day, I’m still a murderer. I should’ve been able to do something better to help.” Izuku finally let go of Kacchan’s hands to bury his head in his hands instead.

“Not everything that falls under the sun is your responsibility, you self-sacrificing nerd.” Kacchan smacked the top of Izuku’s head in frustration.

“But—”

“It’s thanks to you that now, people are much more motivated to help other people— we got a whole new billboard chart just for that, by the way— even though you feel that you didn’t do enough, you still have made a lasting difference in society! Can’t get more heroic than that, you stupid, self-deprecating nerd.” Kacchan started messing Izuku’s hair around relentlessly, ignoring Izuku’s offended squeak.

“What I can’t get behind is, who convinced you that just because you thought you failed at saving one person, you could just walk

away from everything, as if there will never be another person you could still help if only you just reach your hand to them?”

“Well, the crime cases are going down, and Ochako’s counselling—” Izuku reflexively went on the defensive.

“You knew after what happened today the numbers are bullshit. That was a targeted attack, Izuku. There will always be some bad people in this world, or some that’s just dealt a bad hand. There’s just no way Round Face can reach every single one. Do you have any idea how many billions of people live on this planet?”

“I—” Izuku couldn’t find any answer to that. Because deep down he already knew it was true, but his cowardice made him turn a blind eye so he could keep living inside his bubble of faux eternal peace.

“How about you, then?” Izuku challenged, not ready to admit defeat just yet.

“This isn’t about me, nerd,” Kacchan closed his eyes and sighed.

“No, this is about you too, Kacchan. You’re also not giving your all, are you? Don’t tell me that ranking between twelve and sixteen this past year is *Great Explosion Murder God Dynamight* doing his best.” Izuku frowned. Really, it was truly his own cowardice that kept him from thinking beyond ‘well, that’s just how it was.’ Now that the veil

had been lifted, Izuku wholeheartedly believed that there's just *no way* Kacchan's fluctuating ranking was him doing his best. He should be at the top competing with Shoto and Lemillion.

Kacchan let out a growl. "That's none of your business."

"Aren't we communicating like adults now, Kacchan? Do— do you not trust me?" Izuku's self-doubt decided to creep in at the last minute, and his momentary bravado was replaced with hunched shoulders and a frown.

"It just— It just doesn't feel the same without you here, okay? I'm trying so hard, Izuku, I swear I'm trying. But without you to push me, I feel…lost."

"Oh, Kacchan… Why did you never tell me?"

"Because I know you're not ready for this yet." Kacchan's voice was sad but resolute. "If I told you, you'd jump headfirst back into hero work for me without thinking of your own well-being."

Izuku was stunned at Kacchan's reasoning. He would. He *knew* he would. If he knew he made Kacchan *this* sad years earlier, he would jump back to being an active hero in a blink without so much of a thought. It seemed that Kacchan really did know Izuku the best, and

Izuku felt an immeasurable sadness for failing to understand Kacchan as well as he did him.

"I thought I didn't mind waiting for you, no matter how long it takes," Kacchan admitted. "But then, when you became distant, I could feel my resolution faltering bit by bit. Then yesterday, the universe sent your younger self here at my lowest point to remind me of what I'm waiting for. So you can take as much time as you need, Izuku. I've decided. I'm not going anywhere." Kacchan smiled gently, hands tightening around Izuku's to emphasize his resolution.

"Kacchan." Izuku tried to steel his voice in determination, but it came out shaky. His eyes were so close to the classic Midoriya Waterworks for a while now, but he desperately held it in. Kacchan's confession settled deep in his soul and bones, and Izuku's heart almost couldn't contain his affection towards his childhood friend.

"I— I want to feel alright again. I want to fight for the top with you again; I want to win and save with you again. It's—" Izuku sobbed. Sitting in front of his childhood friend, his one and only constant in his life, Izuku's wall finally crumbled into dust. "It's been lonely without you, Kacchan. I'm so sorry that I've been so caught up in my grief that I didn't realize I hurt you, too. I want to get better— I *need* to strive to be better. Once I do, would you please— Do you want— Can we *please* save and win together again?"

A slight tug was all it took. Izuku surged forward the same time Katsuki opened his arms, and both positively melted into each other the moment their bodies flushed against one another. Izuku was

overwhelmed with thousands of emotions, and by the way Kacchan's body trembled against his, he knew that Kacchan must be equally as wrecked, too.

"Kacchan, Kacchan, I love you so much. I'm sorry I took you for granted—"

Kacchan shook his head against Izuku's cheek.

"Did you know? During the war, when I was fighting against nut-sack face…. I made a vow to myself to never stand in your way ever again. So I waited for you. I made damn sure to keep a seat open for you when you finally decided to heal, and I was wrong for that. I'm so sorry, Izuku. I should have never left you alone when you're hurting so much."

"But you were there! All these years, you were always there with me, catching me when I fell, Kacchan, even when I was too blind to see it."

"That's just it, isn't it? Even though I keep convincing myself that I'll be content just to watch you living happily on your own, a selfish part of me doesn't want to be there only to catch you when you fall; I want to be the reason for your happiness, too," Kacchan admitted hoarsely, and Izuku felt his heart clenching at Kacchan's heartfelt confession.

“Kacchan…Don’t you get it? You always make me the happiest, Kacchan. In a way I don’t think I deserve. That’s why I—” Izuku buried his head on Katsuki’s neck, unable to continue without hiccuping.

Kacchan gently cradled Izuku's face between his hands and wiped his tears with his thumb, but this time their faces were only a few centimeters apart.

“Kacchan, can— can I?” Izuku leaned closer, leaving no room for doubt in his intention, and Kacchan’s eyes widened slowly. Izuku watched in rapt attention as a beautiful blush started to spread from the tip of Kacchan’s ears, to his cheeks, to his neck. And— *oh gosh*— Izuku did *that.* The realization that he was the only person who could bring out such a reaction from Kacchan made his heart skip a beat. Izuku was so enamored.

Izuku slowly leaned forward to capture Kacchan’s lips in a kiss for the second time today, and *oh* — Ochako had mentioned something about sparks, yesterday. Their earlier kiss was overloaded with euphoria and relief after saving Kacchan and winning against the villain at the same time to think of it as anything else, but this time, the moment Izuku’s & Kacchan’s lips touched, there was no spark.

The world was… strangely silent.

Izuku didn’t know where he was, and didn't remember who he was. All he knew was Kacchan’s plush lips against his own chapped ones, Kacchan’s little gasp of surprise he happily swallowed with a hum against his lips, the way Kacchan’s tension was melting away from his shoulder under his fingertips, and Kacchan’s slight burnt sugar smell enveloping his very being. The kiss was unhurried, almost chaste, until Izuku, drowning in everything Kacchan, greedily swiped his tongue against Kacchan’s lips. His mouth tasted a little spicy, undoubtedly from their dinner earlier, but the taste was just so *Kacchan* , Izuku decided he couldn’t get enough.

It was as if all of his senses recognized Kacchan and *only Kacchan*, everything else was secondary. Izuku never felt desire like this before, and now that he was blessed enough to get a taste, *oh*, *he’s addicted*. How could he live so long without experiencing this?

I wonder what kind of expression Kacchan makes when he’s kissed, Izuku thought. To his surprise, a pair of ruby eyes met his emerald ones the moment he opened his eyes.

Kacchan was looking at him with so much fondness through his hooded gaze, and Izuku instantly knew Kacchan’s thoughts mirrored his own. In that moment, their feelings had truly become one.

Suddenly, everything was too much. Izuku broke away from the kiss to let out a relieved sigh, and his chest was bubbly with lightness he hadn’t felt in years. Izuku let out a watery giggle, and Kacchan responded with a soft laugh that’s music in Izuku’s ears, before placing his forehead against Izuku’s. For a while, they’re just basking

in each other's presence, hands reaching out to one another with an unspoken promise of forever, for the rest of their lives.

They felt like teenagers again when they came back for more, sharing hundreds of kisses and giggles on the sofa in a dimly lit apartment with a random late-night telenovela playing in the background. They kissed until they ran out of breath, until all the draining events earlier today finally caught up to their body and soul and slowly lulled them to sleep. Before fully drifting away to the dreamland, Izuku thanked whatever quirk or divine intervention sent his younger self to the most crucial moment in his life, changing the course of his life for good. He wholeheartedly prayed that his younger, alternate-dimension self would get his happiness with his Kacchan, too.

At long last, the twin stars fell into line again, chasing and orbiting each other in a beautiful dance across the universe.

✦✧

Chapter End Notes

> Hi, guys! It's been quite a long time. Time flew by so fast, and suddenly it's been two months since that godforsaken chapter leaked and turned my life upside down. I've been loving MHA for almost 10 years, and I felt like this extra chapter fundamentally changed me as a person forever.
>
> On one hand, I started reliving my childhood dream again, first out of spite of Deku who I felt gave up on his own, but slowly I

felt the joy of rediscovering something I love as a child now as an adult. It's an exhilarating feeling! On the other hand, I still felt hollow and low-spirited seeing how one of my favorite manga was tarnished forever by the existence of one chapter. It's hard.

I wrote this to cope. As a form of therapy for myself. Though imperfect as it is, I hope that this small piece of writing could bring comfort to you too! Thank you so much to everyone who left a kudo, bookmarked, subscribed, and commented on the fic! It truly means a lot to me.

I put the fic as complete for now since the main plot is already complete, but I'm planning to do one extra chapter to see how everyone's doing a little while after the event of the main story! It will take a while, since my life is going to be very busy for the next couple of months, but I can't wait to share it with all of you.

Sorry for the long note, guys! Once again, thank you for reading this far, and see you soon!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!